LORDSHIP SALVATION

AND THE GOSPEL OF THE GRACE OF GOD

JOEL FINCK

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By
Joel Finck

A Very Special Thanks

To my fellow laborers in the Gospel:
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I'm sure I've probably missed someone;
Please forgive me!

Pastor Joel Finck
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PART ONE:
LORDSHIP SALVATION IN THE JEWISH PROGRAM

CHAPTER 1
"UNDERSTANDING LORDSHIP SALVATION"

The Gospel of the Grace of God is under attack today, perhaps to a greater degree than any time since the Reformation. The current attack is coming in the form of a doctrine known as "Lordship Salvation." During the past decade or so, Lordship Salvation has become a burning issue among evangelicals. On the one hand, this is good because it is forcing Christians to reevaluate and reexamine that most basic question of life: "What must I do to be saved?" The unfortunate result of this debate is that many believers are becoming desperately confused as some very popular Christian leaders are abandoning the Gospel of the Grace of God for "another gospel." The stakes in this discussion are high. This is not merely a debate on theological fine points. The Lordship Salvation issue strikes at the very heart of the Gospel. The very souls of men are at stake in this debate. As much as the two sides of the Lordship debate differ in their view of how one obtains salvation, both sides agree on this: whoever is wrong is in danger of leading precious souls straight to eternal Hell; both sides admit this. That is why it is so important for us to examine the issue and have a proper Biblical approach to understanding it.

Defining Lordship Salvation

What exactly is Lordship Salvation? The January-March 1986 issue of *Bibliotheca Sacra* (the Journal of Dallas Theological Seminary) defines Lordship Salvation as, "The view that for salvation a person must trust Jesus Christ as his Savior and must also commit himself to Christ as Lord of his life, submitting to His Sovereign Authority."

Lordship Salvation comes in many forms. The most blatant form is the teaching that salvation requires faith plus works. This form is based on such Scripture passages as these: "Whoever believes and is baptized shall be saved" (Mark 16:16); "Repent and be baptized for the remission of sins" (Acts 2:38); and "faith without works, is dead" (James 2:20). Failure to "rightly divide the word of truth" (II Tim. 2:15) has led many Bible teachers to cling to these passages more than the great Pauline texts on justification by faith without works.

A second form of Lordship Salvation states that salvation requires obedience to God. This is similar to the first view, but with a little different twist. It basically says faith is only one of many things that we are to obey, and according to this view, it isn't faith that saves you, it's obedience that saves you.

A third form is the teaching that salvation requires repentance either before, or in conjunction with faith.

A fourth example is most closely associated with the definition given above. This view states that salvation requires total submission to the Lordship of Christ. This form of the teaching affirms belief in the Gospel, but this faith must include the understanding that you are now turning your entire life over to the obedience of God and as long as you are believing in that sense, and following through by showing it with your life, then you are saved.

A final form of Lordship Salvation, which is usually unintentional, involves the many unclear invitations to salvation. One example of this is the statement, "Give your life to Christ and you will be saved." Is salvation obtained by giving something to God, or by receiving something from God? Another unintentional example is, "Pray and ask Jesus to come into your heart and you will be saved." This is a very common invitation to salvation. Does the Bible teach anywhere that if you pray a certain prayer, you will be saved? Another example, which is probably unintentional in most cases, is the admonition to "receive Christ as Lord and Savior." Many evangelists and pastors who would say this probably mean nothing more than "believe the Gospel," but to the Lordship Salvationist, it means far more than to merely believe the Gospel. To these it means total submission, in every area of life, to the Lordship of Christ as evidence of believing the Gospel.

Lordship Salvation is a rather complicated system with all of its forms, but they all have one thing in common. They either state explicitly, or at least imply, that faith alone in the finished work of Christ is not sufficient for salvation. This is the common denominator of all forms of Lordship Salvation.

The Appeal of Lordship Salvation

Lordship Salvation has a strong appeal for several reasons. The first reason is that its proponents claim it is Scriptural. After all, James 2:23 does say "faith without works is dead." In fact, it says it even stronger in James 2:24, "Ye see, then how that by works a man is justified and not by faith only." Well, it's right there, isn't it? "By works, a man is justified, not by faith only." The Lordship Salvationist jumps on that one and proclaims, "It's in the Word of God; it's Scriptural." Of course, what the Lordship Salvationist does not point out is that we must not only be Scriptural, we must also be dispensationally correct. It is also Scriptural to build an ark and fill it with male and female of every kind of animal, but is dispensational to do so? No. It is Scriptural to offer animal sacrifices, but is it dispensationally correct? No, it's not. It is Scriptural to have the ability to handle poisonous snakes and not be harmed by them (and many have died trying to do so) but it is not dispensationally correct. The Book of James was not addressed to the Body of Christ. James 1:1 says, "James, a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ to the twelve tribes which are scattered abroad." This book is clearly addressed to the twelve tribes of Israel. Is the teaching that justification is by works and not by faith only, Scriptural? Yes, it's right there in James. Is it dispensational? No, it's not addressed to us today.

A second reason that Lordship Salvation has a strong appeal is that it appeals to the flesh. Man is, by nature, very religious. Now, do not confuse being religious with being a Christian. Man, by nature, has a strong desire to prove himself to God and to somehow help in his own salvation, if not do it all by himself. This is why religious activities are so popular. This is why religious ritual is so popular. It gratifies the flesh: it gives the flesh something to do for God. And this is why the Grace Message is not very popular. It strips away all human effort when it comes to salvation. We come with nothing, and frankly, people don't like that. But Lordship Salvation offers them the opportunity to have a hand in their salvation. Now, in all fairness, most Lordship Salvation teachers deny that they are teaching salvation by works. And yet, the problem is, their doctrine opens the door to the teaching of salvation by works and can easily be misconstrued as salvation by works.

A third appeal of the Lordship Salvation teaching is that it offers a "solution" (in the minds of its adherents) to the lack of dedication in the lives of so many Christians. Lordship Salvationists decry "easy believism" and "cheap grace" as the cause of the "laxidasical" attitude of many believers toward sin. This problem will be dealt with in a later chapter where we will see that the Apostle Paul offers a better solution to carnality than the threat of eternal damnation if we do not "shape up."

The Origin of Lordship Salvation

The battle against Lordship Salvation is nothing new. The Apostle Paul faced it in his day, and spent a great deal of time in the defense of his message. The very first attack on the Gospel of the Grace of God came shortly after Paul finished his first missionary journey. Paul's first missionary journey is recorded in Acts 13 and records what Paul was preaching at that time. Acts 13:28 says, "And though they found no cause of death in Him (that is, in Christ), yet desired they Pilate that He should be slain. And when they had fulfilled all that was written of Him, they took Him down from the tree and laid Him in a sepulcher, but God raised Him from the dead." Do you see what Paul has just proclaimed? Verse 28, "they desired that He should be slain" (the death of Christ); Verse 29, "they took Him down from the tree and laid Him in a sepulcher" (the burial of Christ), "but God raised Him from the dead" (the resurrection of Christ). This is the Gospel revealed to Paul (see I Corinthians 15:1-4).

Now, notice what he says in Verses 38 and 39, "Be it known unto you therefore men and brethren that through this man is preached unto you the forgiveness of sins; And by him all that believe are Justified from all things from which ye could not be Justified by the law of Moses." Now, did Paul say "All that submit to the Lordship of Christ"? No! Does this mean that Paul does not want us to submit to the Lordship of Christ? Of course not; he wants us to be submissive to Christ in all things. But is submission to His Lordship the condition for being justified? No. The stated condition is, "all that believe." Believe what? Well, what has he just told them? That they took Christ and slew Him and laid Him in a sepulcher and God raised Him up again and all that believe are justified. But then notice Paul also says, "from which ye could not be justified by the law of Moses."

Here is justification by faith, without works. That's what Paul was preaching. Would anyone object to that? Would anyone have any problems with that message? Surely not! Yet consider what happened after Paul had returned from his first missionary journey. "And when they were come and had gathered the church together, they rehearsed all that God had done with them and how that He had opened the door of faith unto the Gentiles and there they abode long time with the disciples. And certain men which came down from Judea, taught the brethren and said, Except ye be circumcised after the manner of Moses ye cannot be saved" (Acts 14:27-15:1). Who was the first person to object to this addition of circumcision? Acts 15:2 continues, "When, therefore, Paul and Barnabas had no small dissension and disputation with them.....The Apostle Paul was the first one to preach the Gospel of Grace! And no sooner had he returned home from doing so, somebody objected to it. Lordship Salvation is nothing new! There has been a battle against salvation by grace through faith alone from the time it was first proclaimed by Paul.

Now, today, it's usually not circumcision that is added to faith for salvation. But that doesn't make any difference. It wouldn't matter what you added to faith, whether it be circumcision or baptism or repentance from sin or praying a prayer or standing on your head. It wouldn't make any difference: if you are including a human work in the process, you've just come up with Lordship Salvation and you have departed from the Gospel of the Grace of God.

Addressing Lordship Salvation

Others have made noble efforts to answer the proponents of Lordship Salvation, so why do we need another book? It is because most who have attempted to answer this doctrine have done so from an "Acts 2" Dispensational position. In our view, answering Lordship Salvation from an Acts 2 perspective will always fall short, because most Acts 2 theologians view the Four Gospels and the writings of Peter, James and John as equally binding on believers today as are the Epistles of Paul. And generally speaking, the strong "Lordship" passages come from the Gospels and from Peter, James and John. Paul's writings are often forced to conform with the writings of the other Apostles so as not to contradict them.

The Grace (Mid-Acts) Dispensational position sees all Scripture as inspired and profitable (II Tim. 3:16), but further recognizes that it was to Paul that God committed the truth for this dispensation (Rom. 11:13; Eph. 3:1-3; I Tim. 2:7 et al.). It is the conviction of this writer that Lordship Salvation is actually a take-off on the Gospel of the Kingdom as preached by Christ and His Twelve Disciples, and that the solution to the controversy is to recognize the distinctive revelation given to the Apostle Paul by the glorified Lord of Heaven.

It is our conviction that salvation under Israel's Kingdom Program has some very basic and essential differences from salvation under the Dispensation of Grace Program for

the Body of Christ. In the course of our study, we will note these differences and point out how they affect the "Lordship" controversy.

CHAPTER 2
"THE TWO GOSPELS"

It comes as a surprise to many to learn that there is more than one Gospel in Scripture; but the fact is, there are and it Is important to understand the difference between them. Scripture speaks of the Gospel of God, the Gospel of Christ, the Gospel of the Kingdom, the Gospel of the Grace of God, the Gospel of the Circumcision, the Gospel of the Uncircumcision. Now granted, some of these are simply different names for the same thing. But as we are going to find in this chapter, all of these phrases can be condensed to two essentially different Gospels.

Galatians 2:7 is a case in point: "But contrariwise, when they saw that the Gospel of the Uncircumcision was committed unto me as the Gospel of the Circumcision was unto Peter..... Here is a case where many modern translations have gone astray. One popular version reads in Verse 7, "On the contrary, they saw that I had been given the task of preaching the Gospel to the Gentiles just as Peter had been given the task of preaching the Gospel to the Jew.....” This translation totally misses the point that Paul is trying to make! Paul is not telling us here who he preached to. He gets to that later on in Verse 9 where he mentions "that when James, Cephas, and John who seem to be pillars perceived the grace that was given unto me, they gave to me and Barnabas the right hands of fellowship that we should go unto the heathen and they unto the circumcision." In that verse, yes, Paul is talking about who he went to preach to, but in Verse 7, he's talking not about who he's preaching to, but rather he's telling us what he preached about.

The grammar in Verse 7 simply will not support translating this "to the Jews," or "to the circumcision" or "to the uncircumcision." Here Paul is using the genitive case, which is similar to the possessive case. Nunn, in his "Elements of N.T. Greek" defines the genitive thus: "The Genitive Case can generally be translated into English by the use of the preposition, 'of,' or by the Possessive Case, formed by adding ('s) to the noun." The same construction is used, for example, in the expression, "The Gospel of the Kingdom." Would we translate this, "the Gospel to the kingdom?" Would that make any sense at all? No! Christ did not preach the Gospel to the Kingdom, He preached the Gospel concerning the Kingdom. It's the Gospel which pertains to, or belongs to the Kingdom and that's what the word "of” conveys. Likewise, when Paul says there is "the Gospel of the Uncircumcision" and "the Gospel of the Circumcision," he's not talking there about who the audience is, he's talking about the content of the message! The keys to these verses, and to our study in general, are the two words "circumcision" and "Uncircumcision."

The Gospel of the Circumcision

Lordship Salvation is actually none other than the Gospel of the Circumcision. It is the Gospel that was designed for the nation of Israel, for the Kingdom program, and it is not the message for this Dispensation of Grace. Under this heading, we will be asking the question, "How did salvation operate before this Dispensation of Grace began?" In order to understand this, we need to understand the covenants that were given to Israel. We find in Scripture that Israel was given two kinds of covenants. The one kind is called an unconditional covenant. It's simply a promise God makes to a group of people or a person. It has nothing to do with their response or what they do. It's an unconditional promise. The other kind of covenant is a conditional covenant. This kind of covenant says. "Here is what I will do if you do this." A conditional covenant also says, "If you do not do this, then you will not get the blessings or benefits of this covenant."

Salvation Under the Covenants

One of the major covenants in the Scriptures is the covenant of promise found in Genesis 12:2,3 where God promised Abram "And I will make of thee a great nation, and I will bless thee, and make thy name great; and thou shalt be a blessing. And I will bless them that bless thee, and curse him that curseth thee: and in thee shall all families of the earth be blessed." This covenant is unconditional. God simply promised these things to Abram; it had nothing to do with what he did.

Now, what did this promise basically say? Its essential message was that God was going to bless all people through Abraham's seed, the family through which Christ would come. In Genesis chapter 15, God reaffirms the covenant. Yet, Abram still had no children, and he brings this up to the Lord (Vs. 2). At this, God reaffirms that Abram's seed would be as numerous as the stars of Heaven (Vs. 5). Abram's response is recorded in that glorious verse, "And he believed in the Lord and He counted it to him for righteousness" (Gen. 15:6). Abram believed God even though he didn't have any children, and he did not have many prospects, humanly speaking of having any. He just believed God, and it was counted to him for righteousness. Now, did he do something to get that righteousness? Did he have to perform some action, fulfill any conditions? No, he just believed and it was counted to him for righteousness.

However, as we page a little further to Genesis Chapter 17, we find that now God establishes some conditions for participating in this promise. We're going to find that there are two major conditions that have been added throughout the course of history. The first one is the covenant of circumcision. Genesis 17:4-8, "As for me, behold, my covenant is with thee, and thou shalt be a father of many nations. Neither shall thy name be anymore called Abram, but thy name shall be Abraham; for a father of many nations have I made thee and I will make thee exceeding fruitful, and I will make nations of thee, and kings shall come out of thee. And I will establish my covenant between me and thee and thy seed after thee in their generations for an everlasting covenant, to be a God unto thee and to thy seed after thee. I will give unto thee, and to thy seed after thee, the land wherein thou art the stranger, all the land of Canaan, for an everlasting

possession; and I will be their God." So far, it looks like God is simply restating what He has already said.

But, in Verses 9 & 10, God continues, "Thou shalt keep my covenant therefore, thou, and thy seed after thee in their generations. This is my covenant, which ye shall keep, between me and you and thy seed after thee: Every man child among you shall be circumcised." Abraham may well have thought, "Wait a minute, I thought you said that you were going to promise me this covenant and these blessings unconditionally. How is it now that you are requiring the male children to be circumcised"? How can God be adding this condition? The answer is simply this: God is not changing the promise; the promise still stands. Abraham would still be a great nation, he would still be blessed, and he would still be a blessing. The promise is still there. The condition now regulates who gets to participate in this promise. The original promise is still unconditional. But those who get to join in and participate in this blessing could now do so only upon the condition that they be circumcised. From Genesis 17 on, with the exception of this dispensation (which will be considered later), to participate in the program, all male children had to be circumcised. Salvation under the covenant consisted of being identified with the people of God. And in order to be identified with the people of God according to Genesis 17, Verse 14 says, "And the uncircumcised man child who's flesh of his foreskin is not circumcised, that soul shall be - cut off from his people. He hath broken my covenant." Now why does it say, "cut off from his people"? It is because salvation under the covenant requires being identified with the people of God. To be cut off from the people is to be cut off from the promise along with the blessing. The condition given to participate is circumcision. This is why Paul calls Peter's message the Gospel of the Circumcision: it is because circumcision was the requirement for participating in that program.

This is also why in Acts Chapter 15, Verse 1, after the Apostle Paul was out preaching the Gospel of Grace, certain men came down from Jerusalem, Judea and said, "Except ye be circumcised after the manner of Moses, ye cannot be saved." Why were they saying this? Didn't they know the Scriptures? Yes they did, and that's why they were saying it. They knew Scripture, therefore they knew Genesis 17 said if any were not circumcised, they were cut off from the people and were, therefore, separated from the covenant. Paul had been given a new revelation which did not require that men be circumcised to be a part of God's offer of salvation. But, in Acts 15 there were still many people around who had been a part of the covenant and they knew that circumcism was required.

"The Law Was Added"

Now, let us consider another covenant which modifies who can participate. In Exodus, Chapter 19 we find the covenant of the Law. In this context, Israel has just come out of Egypt. Now they are awaiting God's direction on what to do next. Moses went up to talk with God where He told him, "Ye have seen what I did unto the Egyptians, and how I bore you on eagles' wings and brought you unto myself Now therefore, if you wiIl obey my voice indeed, and keep my covenant, then ye shall be a peculiar treasure unto me

above all people, for all the earth is mine" (Exo. 19:4,5). Again, some might object: "Wait a minute, Lord, I thought you unconditionally promised Abraham that his seed would become a great nation and bless the earth." Yes, that is true and that promise still stands at this point here in Exodus 19. Now God is simply qualifying and limiting who can participate. He has already added circumcision to participate in the covenant, now He is adding the Law as a requirement for participation.

Again, some might ask, "Lord how can you do this? Have you gone back on your promise?" The answer is, "No," and Paul explains this in Galatians 3:17-18, "And this I say that the covenant that was confirmed before of God in Christ, the Law, which was four hundred and thirty years after cannot disannul, that it should make the promise of no effect. For if the inheritance be of the Law, it is no more of promise; but God gave it to Abraham by promise." Paul is saying the Law does not change the original promise: it still stands, but the logical question is, "What is the purpose of the Law?" That is what Paul asks and answers in the next verse: "Wherefore, then, serveth the Law. It was added because of transgressions, till the seed should come to whom the promise was made; and it was ordained by angels In the hand of a mediator" (Gal. 3:19). Because of the transgression, God came to His people Israel and told them, the promise still stands, but if you want to be a part of it, here's what you have to do. Then He set forth the Law. What happened if an Israelite refused to keep the Law? Let's find out. Exodus 31:14, "Ye shall keep the Sabbath therefore, for it is holy unto you. Everyone that defileth it shall surely be put to death. For whosoever doeth any work therein, that soul shall be cut off from among His people." Here is that statement again. Remember, under the covenant, salvation is found in identifying with the people of God. To be cut off from the people, from God's people, is to be cut off from the covenant. And here he says, if anyone does not keep the Sabbath, let that soul be cut off from among His people. This is why the message of the Old Testament and of Christ and of the Twelve Apostles was the same. Get back to the covenant (see Luke 1:72).

Let us note some examples of the importance of keeping the covenant. Throughout Israel's wilderness wanderings, they started getting away from the covenant. Deuteronomy is the second giving of the Law, forty years after the first giving of the Law. Notice what the message is in Deuteronomy 7:9-11, "Know, therefore, that the Lord thy God, He is God, the faithful God, which keepeth covenant and mercy with them that love Him and keep His commandments to a thousand generations, and repayeth them that hate Him to their face, to destroy them; He will not be slack to him that hateth Him, He will repay him to his face. Thou shalt therefore keep the commandments, and the statutes, and the judgements, which I command thee this day, to do them." Get back to the covenant!

Another example of the importance of keeping the covenant is found in Deuteronomy 29:9. "Keep therefore the words of this covenant, and do them, that ye may prosper in all that ye do." Then in Verse 20 we find what will happen to those who ignore the covenant, "The Lord will not spare him, but then the anger of the Lord and His jealousy shall smoke against that man, and all the curses that are written in this book shall lie upon him, and the Lord shall blot out his name from under Heaven."

An often-asked question is, "What about Gentiles during the time of the covenant? How could they be a part of God's program? God takes this into consideration, and in Isaiah he tells us. Isaiah 56:6,7, "Also the sons of the stranger, that join themselves to the Lord, to serve Him, and to love the name of the Lord, to be His servants, every one that keepeth the Sabbath from polluting it, and taketh hold of my covenant. Even them will I bring to my holy mountain, and make them joyful in my house of prayer: their burnt offerings and their sacrifices and they shall be accepted upon mine altar; and mine house shall be called an house of prayer for all people." Therefore, under the covenant, all people, including Gentiles, were permitted to come and participate.

Now, about this point, some might be thinking, Old Testament covenant salvation almost sounds like salvation by works. God keeps saying things like, "If you do this ... you must do this ... you must keep this..... Is God saying these works would save them? Not exactly, and Paul comments on it in Romans 9:31-32. Now keep in mind, under the covenant, not only did you have to do these things, you had to do them in faith. "But Israel, which followed after the Law of righteousness, hath not attained to the Law of righteousness" (Rom 9:31). If the Israelites tried to keep the Law, and did it to the best of their ability, why didn't they attain to the law of righteousness? Paul answers in Verse 32, "Because they sought it not BY FAITH, but as it were by the works of the Law. For they stumble at the stumbling stone." What Paul is saying is that in the Old Testament, if a person kept all of the rules, all of the laws, offered the sacrifices, and yet just did it out of ritual, that wasn't good enough. He had to do it in faith.

Therefore, we can conclude that under the covenant, they did have to believe, but their faith had to be demonstrated by their works. In the case of the covenant, they had to be circumcised, and they had to keep the Law. Works alone were not enough. Faith alone was not enough either, at that time. This is why James, writing to the Twelve Tribes (James 1:1) summarizes covenant salvation with these words: "Even so faith, if it hath not works, is dead, being alone. Yea, a man may say, Thou hast faith, and I have works:show me thy faith without thy works, and I will show thee my faith by my works" (James 2:17,18). This is covenant salvation: show your faith by your works. If you do not have any works, your faith is dead, useless. This is covenant salvation, and this is also Lordship Salvation. Where does Lordship Salvation get its gospel? From James, and from the teaching of Christ while He was on earth as a minister of the circumcism.

Covenant Salvation in the Time of Christ

"Now I say that Jesus Christ was a minister of the circumcism for the truth of God, to confirm the promises made unto the fathers" (Rom. 15:8). Did Christ teach covenant keeping? Yes He did! The covenant continued under Christ, as we will see in Luke Chapter 1. Once again, we will see that the original promise given to Abraham is still unconditional during the time of Christ. Hear the marvelous prophecy of Zacharias, the father of John the Baptist, "Blessed be the Lord God of Israel; for He hath visited and redeemed His people, and hath raised up an horn of salvation for us in the house of His servant David; As He spake by the mouth of His holy prophets, which have been since

the world began: That we should be saved from our enemies, and from the hand of all that hate us; To perform the mercy promised to our fathers, and to remember His holy covenant; The oath which He sware to our father Abraham" (Luke 1:68-73).

The covenant is clearly in full force at the time of Christ. But, did that mean that all Israelites were automatically saved? No. In order to participate in the promise, they had to do certain things. Participation in the promise was still conditional. What were these conditions? Let us consider a few of them. Matthew 6:14,15, "For if ye forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly father will also forgive you: But if ye forgive not men their trespasses, neither will your father forgive your trespasses." Matthew 7:21, "Not everyone that sayeth unto me, Lord, Lord, shall enter into the kingdom of heaven; but he that doeth the will of my Father which is in Heaven."

But what about the Law? Surely, Christ didn't tell them that they had to keep the Law in order to be saved, did He? Let Christ's own words speak for themselves: "And, behold, one came and said unto Him, Good Master, what good thing shall I do, that I may have eternal life? And He said unto him, Why callest thou me good? There is none good but one, that is, God: but if thou will enter into life, KEEP THE COMMANDMENTS. He saith unto Him, Which? Jesus said, Thou shalt do no murder, Thou shalt not commit adultery, Thou shalt not steal, Thou shalt not bear false witness, Honor thy father and thy mother: and, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself' (Matt. 19:16-19). Did the Lord teach that participating in eternal life was conditional? Yes he did. Of course they had to believe, but they also had to do certain things to show their faith.

We could go on and on, but Christ’s teaching on the necessity of works to demonstrate one's faith is summarized in Matthew 7:15-20, "Beware of false prophets, which come to you in sheep's clothing, but inwardly are ravening wolves. Ye shall know them by their fruits. Do men gather grapes of thorns, or figs of thistles? Even so, every good tree bringeth forth good fruit; but a corrupt tree bringeth forth evil fruit. A good tree cannot bring forth evil fruit, neither can a corrupt tree bring forth good fruit. Every tree that bringeth not forth good fruit is hewn down and cast into the fire. Wherefore by their fruits ye shall know them." That is salvation under the covenant, and that is exactly what Lordship Salvation is teaching. These are not isolated texts. The message of the Old Testament and of the Four Gospels is this: "Not only must you believe, you must also do. You must keep the covenant. You must show your faith through forgiving and by bearing fruit, otherwise, you will be cast into the fire and burned." That is the message of the Gospel of the Circumcism and that is the message of Lordship Salvation; but, it is not the message for this present age.

The Gospel of the Uncircumcision

In the remainder of this chapter, let us briefly consider the Gospel of the Uncircumcision. Through the Apostle Paul, God committed a new revelation unto the Body of Christ, and He gave a gospel to go with it. Our text in Galatians 2:7 calls this gospel "the Gospel of the Uncircumcision." We will see why it's called that in a moment. But what has become of the promise? Remember that the promise, which we have

seen all along, was made to Abraham and to his "seed." Paul brings this up in Galatians Chapter three and makes a special application for us. God is still bringing blessing through Abraham's seed, but not in the same way that he did under the covenant. Under the covenant, salvation came by being identified with Israel, God's chosen people.

Today, salvation comes by being identified with the Lord Jesus Christ by faith. Galatians 3:16 says, "Now to Abraham and his seed were the promises made. He saith not, and to seeds, as of many; but as of one, And to thy seed, which is Christ." So today, we do not gain access to the blessing of the promise by being identified with the people of God, Israel - that won't work anymore. Now we gain access by being identified with that singular "seed," the Lord Jesus Christ. Furthermore, the conditions for participating in the promise have changed. Before this dispensation, one had to believe, repent, keep the commandments, be baptized, and the granddaddy of all conditions, be circumcised. Those were the conditions if you wanted to participate in God's promise. But under Paul's ministry, God has rolled back the conditions. He has blotted out the handwriting of ordinances which was against us and which was contrary to us (see Col. 2:14). No longer do we have to keep the Law to be saved. No longer do we have to be baptized. No longer do we have to be circumcised. This is why Paul's Gospel is called the Gospel of the UNcircumcision. It is the Gospel whereby you can be justified the same way Abram was justified before he was circumcised (see Appendix 1, "Weren't men always justified by faith without works?").

Paul is very careful to point this distinction out in Romans 4:2, "For if Abraham were Justified by works, he hath whereof to glory; but not before God. For what saith the Scripture? Abraham believed God, and it was counted unto him for righteousness." Then in Verse 10, Paul asks, "How was it then reckoned? when he was in circumcision, or in Uncircumcision?" Paul's answer, in the latter part of Verse 10 is, "not in circumcision, but in Uncircumcision." And that's why the Apostle Paul, by inspiration of the Holy Spirit, calls his message "the Gospel of the Uncircumcision." No conditions or strings are attached, just simple faith in the Gospel message revealed to Paul, "that Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures; and that He was buried, and that He rose again the third day according to the Scriptures" (I Cor. 15:3,4).

Lordship Salvation must, of necessity, identify itself with Covenant Theology. They must reject dispensational theology - and indeed those preachers who are preaching Lordship Salvation are moving away from "rightly dividing the Word of Truth" (II Tim. 2:15). They are going back to some form of Covenant Theology. To put it another way, those who adhere to Covenant Theology must, in the end, proclaim Lordship Salvation if they are going to be consistent (see Appendix 2 for further discussion of the Calvinist connection to Lordship Salvation). Let us be careful not to mix the two Gospels which the Word of God goes to great lengths to distinguish and keep separate.

CHAPTER 3
"SALVATION IN THE JEWISH EPISTLES"

Lordship Salvation teaches that if faith is not demonstrated by works, that faith is vain. In the previous chapter, we showed that this is precisely what is taught in the Old Testament. We do not deny that the Old Testament teaches that in order to demonstrate faith in God, one must keep the Law, offer sacrifices, and perform the ordinances of the Law. We also showed that the Lord Jesus Christ Himself taught that if one does not have fruit as evidence of faith, that faith is not genuine. This is consistent with "the Gospel of the Kingdom" preached by John the Baptist, Christ, and the Twelve Apostles. This message is also called "the Gospel of the Circumcision," that program which relates to the people of Israel and the Jewish program. The Lordship Salvation controversy is not merely a doctrinal issue, it is a dispensational issue.

In this chapter, we will consider a few examples of Lordship Salvation as taught in the Jewish Epistles. What do we mean by the "Jewish Epistles?" We are referring to the New Testament books of Hebrews through Jude. It is our sincere conviction that these letters were addressed to the Kingdom (or "circumcision") believers who believed in Christ as their Messiah under the ministry of Christ and the Twelve Apostles. Furthermore, it is our belief that these letters do not specifically address the Church, the "Body of Christ," which Paul so eloquently addresses in his writings.

Why should we consider the non-Pauline Epistles as Jewish in nature? For several reasons. *First,* when Peter, James and John met with Paul at the Jerusalem counsel, a solemn agreement was made between them. This agreement is recorded in Galatians 2:9, "And when James, Cephas, and John, who seemed to be pillars, perceived the grace that was given unto me, they gave to me and Barnabas the right hands of fellowship; that we should go to the heathen, and they unto the circumcision." If Peter, James and John were men of their word (which we believe they were), then it follows that they confined their ministry to the "circumcision" believers in accordance with this agreement. This would include their ministries of writing, as we shall see in a moment.

Secondly, to see the non-Pauline Epistles as Jewish in nature is by the addresses found in these letters. For example, James clearly writes "to the twelve tribes which are scattered abroad" (James 1:1). Peter writes "to the strangers scattered throughout..." various lands (I Pet. 1:1). The original Greek here reads "the sojourners of the dispersion" (Gk. "diaspora"), which is the same word James uses when he says "scattered abroad." Who were these "sojourners of the dispersion"? They were the Jewish pilgrims who had gathered in Jerusalem on the day of Pentecost, but later had been chased out of town by Saul of Tarsus (see Acts 8:1)! John addresses his readers as "my little children" (I John 2:1), which would clearly identify them as his personal converts. This would mean they also fall under the classification of "the circumcision" in accordance with Galatians 2:9.

Thirdly, to view the Books of Hebrews through Jude as "Jewish Epistles" is because of the contents of their message. These epistles clearly present a soteriology (doctrine of

salvation) which is compatible with the Jewish program, not with the Dispensation of Grace committed to the Apostle Paul. We shall show this by giving an example (or examples) of this from each of these letters.

Hebrews

An early church father wrote, "who wrote the Book of Hebrews, God only knows." And ever since, good men have differed on the human authorship of this great book. The important thing is that Hebrews is inspired of the Holy Spirit and profitable to our discussion. The writer states, "How shall we escape, if we neglect so great salvation-, which at the first began to be spoken by the Lord, and was confirmed unto us by them that heard Him" (Heb. 2:3). Whoever wrote this, had received his message from those who heard the Lord directly. This would strongly indicate that Paul did not write Hebrews, for he states in Galatians, "But I certify you, brethren, that the Gospel which was preached of me is not after man. For I neither received it of man, neither was I taught it, but by the revelation of Jesus Christ" (Gal. 1:11,12). Furthermore, Paul writes, "for they who seemed to be somewhat in conference added nothing to me" (Gal. 2:6b).

More important, though, than knowing who wrote Hebrews, is recognizing the nature of its message. The soteriology of this book is geared toward the Covenant/Lordship type of salvation: that is, faith must be coupled with, or demonstrated by, obedience for it to be genuine. A case in point is Hebrews 5:9, "And being made perfect, He became the author of eternal salvation unto all them that obey Him." Now, let us think about this for a moment. Is this the doctrine of salvation for the Dispensation of Grace, or for the Jewish Kingdom program? It clearly reflects the Kingdom program. This is the Book of "Hebrews" after all, and it says, He is the author of eternal salvation unto all them that "obey" Him. In this Dispensation of Grace, He is the author of salvation to those who "believe" in His finished work on the Cross. "Even the righteousness of God which is by (the) faith of Jesus Christ unto all and upon all them that believe..." (Rom. 3:22).

James

Looking at the address, James 1:1 says, "James, a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ, to the Twelve Tribes which are scattered abroad." What does James tell the Twelve Tribes about being justified? "Ye see then how that by works a man is Justified, and not by faith only" (James 2:24). This verse has been a stumbling block to many. It was a stumbling block five-hundred years ago when Martin Luther read it. He knew, deep down from his study of the Pauline Epistles, that justification was by faith without works. "But to him that worketh not, but believeth on Him that justifieth the ungodly, his faith is counted for righteousness" (Rom. 4:5). And yet, when he turned to James, he read, "Ye see then how that by works a man is justified, and not by faith only." Martin Luther scratched his head and concluded that James was "an epistle of straw." And there have been a lot of theologians scratching their heads ever since. Again, if we would merely "rightly divide the Word of Truth," we would find the solution to the dilemma. God's Jewish/Covenant salvation requires works as evidence of faith, and God's Grace salvation requires faith alone.

Peter

Several denominations teach some form of "baptismal regeneration" based on such Scriptures as Mark 16:16 and Acts 2:38. It is certainly true that Peter associates forgiveness of sins with baptism when he says to the "house of Israel" (Acts 2:36), "Repent, and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins..." (Acts 2:38). Peter explains this necessity of baptism under the Jewish program in I Peter 3:21, "The like figure whereunto even baptism doth also now save us (not the putting away of the filth of the flesh, but the answer of a good conscience toward God,) by the resurrection of Jesus Christ." While some have interpreted Peter's words to mean that water baptism was unnecessary for his readers, he is actually reaffirming and explaining what he preached in Acts 2:38. Peter is telling his readers that it is not the water ceremony (the putting away of the filth of the flesh) alone that saves them, but the answer of a good conscience to God which was demonstrated by their water ceremony. This is similar to what the author of Hebrews writes in Hebrews 10:22, "Let us draw near with a true heart in full assurance of faith, having our hearts sprinkled from an evil conscience, and our bodies washed with pure water." In both Hebrews and I Peter, the conscience is cleared before God through a water washing. Once again, this is not Paul's teaching of grace, but the Covenant/Lordship teaching of faith demonstrated by works.

Consider another passage: "And beside this, giving all diligence, add to your faith virtue; and to virtue knowledge; and to knowledge temperance; and to temperance patience and to patience godliness; and to godliness brotherly kindness; and to brotherly kindness charity. For if these things be in you, and abound, they make you that ye shall neither be barren nor unfruitful in the knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ. But he that lacketh these things is blind, and cannot see afar off, and hath forgotten that he was purged from his old sins. Wherefore the rather, brethren, give diligence to make your calling and election sure: for if ye do these things, ye shall never fall; For so an entrance shall be ministered unto you abundantly unto the everlasting kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ" (II Pet. 1:5-11). Here, entrance into the Kingdom requires that the readers "add to" their "faith" (Vs. 5) and that they "do these things" (Vs. 10). Again, this is not a principle revealed to Paul for the Dispensation of Grace, but rather a principle revealed to Peter for "the circumcision" believers of the Jewish Covenant program. It also agrees with the modern teaching of Lordship Salvation.

John

A much-used (and misused) verse of Scripture is I John 1:9, "if we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness." How foreign this verse seems to those who understand forgiveness as preached by Paul! In Colossians 1:14 we are told, "in Whom we have redemption through His blood, even the forgiveness of sins." Nothing is said about a need to confess these sins: our forgiveness is found "in Christ," period! But under the Kingdom Program, a distinction is made between "old sins" which have already been purged (II Pet. 1:9), and those new

sins which still needed to be confessed in order for them to be forgiven (I John 1:9). It was important for the Hebrew believer, under the Kingdom Program, to continue in the faith and endure unto the end to be saved (See Appendix 3).

I John 3:9 is another example of the Gospel of the Kingdom as applied to the believer in the Jewish dispensation. These Jewish Epistles applied to the circumcision believers of the first century and will come into their fullness during the Tribulation period. But trying to apply certain statements from these letters today has led to serious theological error. Take for example I John 3:7-9, "Little children, let no man deceive you; he that doeth righteousness is righteous, even as He is righteous. He that committeth sin is of the Devil; for the devil sinneth from the beginning. For this purpose the Son of God was manifested, that He might destroy the works of the Devil. Whosoever is born of God doth not commit sin; for His seed remaineth in him: and he cannot sin, because he is born of God." Those who teach Lordship Salvation try to apply this Scripture to this Dispensation of Grace and teach that if a person is committing sin, or living in sin, they can not possibly be saved.

Jude

Jude Verse 24 is sometimes used as a verse on security, "Now unto Him that is able to keep you from falling, and to present you faultless before the presence of His glory with exceeding joy." While this is a wonderful promise to these circumcision believers, this verse only gives the Divine side of the equation. Of course, God is able to do these things, but just three verses earlier, Jude gives the human responsibility of the Kingdom saint: "Keep yourselves in the love of God, looking for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ unto eternal life" (Vs. 2). Again, how different this is from the teaching committed to Paul for the Body of Christ. Paul does not say, "keep yourselves in the love of God"; No, he writes that nothing "shall be able to separate us from the love of God..." (Rom. 8:38, 39).

Revelation

While we have been primarily concerned with the Jewish Epistles in this chapter, we want to include a few references from the Book of Revelation to show its consistency with Jewish/Covenant salvation. The whole tenor of the letters to the seven churches in Revelation, Chapters two and three, is that one must "overcome" in order to partake of eternal life. "Nevertheless I have somewhat against thee, because thou hast left thy first love. Remember therefore from whence thou art fallen, and repent, and do the first works; or else I will come unto thee quickly, and will remove thy candlestick out of his place, except thou repent" (Rev. 2:4,5). How striking, "...do the first works; or else..."!

Many interpret the "or else" as merely a loss of rewards, but notice Verse eleven, "He that overcometh shall not be hurt of the second death" (Rev. 2:11). The "second death," of course, is eternal banishment to the Lake of Fire (Rev. 20:14,15). Failure to "overcome" is not just a loss of reward, it results in eternal damnation in Hell (see Appendix 3 for further discussion of the security of the Kingdom saint). But to the one

who remains faithful, God promises, "be thou faithful unto death, and I will give thee a crown of life" (Rev. 2:10).

Here is the essence of Jewish Covenant salvation: repenting, continuing in faith, and doing the first works. This is also the essence of Lordship Salvation. If one were to remove the writings of Paul from the Bible, it would be difficult indeed to build a case against the teaching of Lordship Salvation. The necessity of good works AS EVIDENCE OF FAITH is clearly taught in the Old Testament, in the Four Gospels, and in the Jewish Epistles.

PART TWO: DOES PAUL TEACH LORDSHIP SALVATION?

CHAPTER 4 "THE GOSPEL PREACHED BY PAUL"

While the proponents of Lordship Salvation have leaned heavily on "the gospel according to Jesus" and the book of James, they have felt, of course, a need to reconcile the teachings of Paul with their conclusions. After all, few believers would deny the importance of nearly one-half of the New Testament books. However, in the rush to include Paul as a preacher of the same "faith-works" gospel as found in the Covenant system of Israel, some important facts have been overlooked.

A New Revelation

One of these is the fact that Paul insists time and time again that the Gospel he preached was an entirely new revelation from Christ, and not merely a message handed down from the other Apostles. In several places, Paul makes it abundantly clear that the things he taught were not his own words, but, rather, they were the very words of the risen and ascended Christ. "If any man think himself to be a prophet, or spiritual, let him acknowledge that the things that I write unto you are the commandments of the Lord" (I Cor. 14:37). "Since ye seek a proof of Christ speaking in me, which to you-ward is not weak, but is mighty in you" (II Cor. 13:3). "But I certify you, brethren, that the Gospel which was preached of me is not after man. For I neither received it of man, neither was I taught it, but by the revelation of Jesus Christ" (Gal. 1:11, 12).

A question which most Christians have never considered is this: if Paul simply preached the same Gospel as the Twelve Apostles, why did Christ need to give him a new revelation? He could have simply learned the message from the Twelve. For that matter, if there is no change of message or program from the time of Christ until today, why did God need to raise up a new Apostle anyway? Some would answer, "Paul was raised to take the message to the Gentiles." But had not the Twelve already been commissioned to go "Into all the world?" Yes, they had (see Mark 16:15). The truth is,

Paul was raised up by God, yes, to go to the Gentiles. But more than that, Paul was given a new Gospel which invited the Gentiles to salvation totally apart from the circumcision/works gospel of the Jewish program. As the Apostle of the Gentiles so eloquently states by inspiration of the Holy Spirit, "But now the righteousness of God without the Law is manifested, being witnessed by the Law and the prophets" (Rom. 3:21). Before the new revelation was given to Paul, the righteousness of God had been revealed, but not to "without" (apart from) the Law.

Paul's Gospel

We are sure that some will object to our sub-heading, "Paul's Gospel." Yet, this is the Biblical terminology of the inspired Apostle himself "In the day when God shall Judge the secrets of men by Jesus Christ according to MY GOSPEL" (Rom. 2:16). "Now to Him that is of power to stablish you according to MY GOSPEL, and the preaching of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the Mystery, which was kept secret since the world began" (Rom. 16:25). "Remember that Jesus Christ of the seed of David was raised from the dead according to MY GOSPEL" (II Tim. 2:8). What was Paul's Gospel? It was the Gospel of the Grace of God (Acts 20:24), and the essence of this message is salvation by grace through faith without works.

Let us go to Paul’s Epistles and see some examples of this. In many salvation verses in Paul's writings, he simply mentions faith, or belief, without mentioning works at all. "Therefore being Justified by FAITH, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ" (Rom. 5:1). Here we find no mention of works, positive or negative, but simply that we are justified by faith. In I Corinthians 1:21, we read, "For after that in the wisdom of God the world by wisdom knew not God, it pleased God by the foolishness of preaching to save them that BELIEVE." Again, he does not say "obey and do certain works," simply, "believe."

But Paul often goes on to explain that not only is faith enough, it must be faith alone in the finished work of Christ without works. Romans 4:4, "Now to him that worketh is the reward not reckoned of grace, but of debt." Here Paul points out that if the system of salvation today were a matter of working for something, we really couldn't call it grace. It would be a debt. But we are not under that kind of system, we are under grace (Rom. 6:14). Then he continues in Verse 5, "But to him that worketh not, but belleveth on Him that justifieth the ungodly, his faith is counted for righteousness." Did you see it? Paul not only says faith is enough, but he says it must be a faith that is entirely separate from works. In this dispensation, there is no specified work that is required to manifest your faith; no work that is associated with salvation. What happens when any kind of work is added to faith for salvation? It mixes the Gospel of Grace with the Gospel of the Kingdom, and nullifies grace. In Romans 11:6, the Apostle Paul is very careful to keep the distinction clear between faith and works: "And if by grace, then it is no more of works: otherwise grace is no more grace .....”

Time and time again, Paul separates faith from works; Gal 2:16, "Knowing that a man is not justified by the works of the Law, but by the faith of Jesus Christ, even we have

believed in Jesus Christ, that we might be justified by the faith of Christ, and not by the works of the Law: for by the works of the Law shall no flesh be justified." How could it be said any clearer than that? Eph. 2:8-9, "For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: Not of works, lest any man should boast." Titus 3:5, "Not by works of righteousness which we have done, but according to His mercy He saved us, by the washing of regeneration, and renewing of the Holy Ghost." "NOT BY WORKS OF RIGHTEOUSNESS." Didn't the other Apostles always teach that? No! In Acts 10:35, the Apostle Peter says, "But in every nation he that feareth Him, AND WORKETH RIGHTEOUSNESS, is accepted with Him." Paul says in Titus 3:5, "NOT BY WORKS OF RIGHTEOUSNESS." Do you see the difference? It is as plain as day. In the one program, works of righteousness must be evident to be "accepted with Him." In the other program, faith alone, "not by works of righteousness," is required to be "accepted in the beloved" (Eph. 1:6). The Apostle Paul is clear. The Gospel he preached is a Gospel of faith alone without works. And yet, the proponents of Lordship Salvation contend that Paul does require works, or fruit as evidence of faith.

The Terms of the Gospel of Grace

What do we mean by the "terms of the Gospel"? Webster defines "terms" as the "conditions of a contract, agreement, sale, etc. that limit or define its scope or the action involved." We have already seen many passages where Paul preaches that faith alone without works is the requirement God has established for salvation. But the next question is, "faith in what?" Obviously, we must have faith in Christ. Yet, under the Gospel of Grace, Paul brings out an emphasis which was not a part of the Gospel of the Kingdom. That is, the finished work of Christ on the Cross.

Under the Kingdom Gospel for Israel, the emphasis was on the "name" of Christ: "But as many as received Him, to them gave He power to become the sons of God, even to them that believe on His NAME" (John 1:12). "But these are written, that ye might believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God; and that believing ye might have life through His NAME" (John 20:31). "These things have I written unto you that believe on the NAME of the Son of God; that ye may know that ye have eternal life, and that ye may believe on the NAME of the Son of God" (I John 5:13). Why does the Kingdom Gospel emphasize the "name" of Christ? It is because the main object of Israel's faith is Christ as the Messiah, the Son of God. Of course, we, too, recognize Christ as the Great Messiah, but under Grace, the object of our faith is to be Christ as the Great Savior of man through His perfect work at Calvary.

Paul summarizes this work of Christ and identifies it as the "Gospel" which he "received" from Christ in I Corinthians 15:1-4, "Moreover, brethren I declare unto you THE GOSPEL which I preached unto you, which also ye have received, and wherein ye stand; By which also ye are saved, if ye keep in memory what I preached unto you, unless ye have believed in vain. For I delivered unto you first of all that which I also received, how that Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures; And that He was buried, and that He rose again the third day according to the Scriptures." Here is the

Gospel in a nutshell: faith in Christ's death for our sins and His victorious resurrection from the grave.

It has been noted that Paul does not always mention all three elements of the Gospel: His death, burial and resurrection. This is true. Romans 5:8 says, "...Christ died for us" (only His death is mentioned). Romans 10:9 says, "That if thou shalt confess with thy mouth the Lord Jesus, and shalt believe in thine heart that God hath raised Him from the dead, thou shalt be saved" (only His resurrection is mentioned). I Thessalonians 4:14 states, "For if we believe that Jesus died and rose again..." (His death and resurrection are mentioned). But in I Corinthians 15 where Paul specifically refers to "the Gospel" which he "received" (from Christ), he mentions all three: Christ's death, burial and resurrection. Therefore, in this writer's opinion, including all three elements in a Gospel presentation "to me indeed is not grievous and to you it is safe."

In summary, Paul preached a very clear and simple message: "Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ and thou shalt be saved" (Acts 16:31). The object of one's faith is to be Christ and His finished work at Calvary as demonstrated through His death for our sins, His burial, and resurrection from the grave. Paul calls this, collectively, "the preaching (word) of the Cross" (I Cor. 1:18). This faith must be totally disconnected from works (Rom. 4:5) to be efficacious.

In the light of this brief examination of Paul's Gospel, how could anyone arrive at the conclusion that the Apostle of the Gentiles preached anything resembling a "Lordship" Gospel which requires works of fruit as evidence of faith? This will be the subject of our next chapter.

CHAPTER 5
"PAULINE 'PROOF-TEXTS' FOR LORDSHIP SALVATION"

In this chapter, we will take some typical Lordship Salvation statements, along with the Pauline verses used to support these statements. We will then examine these conclusions based on the contexts and exegesis of these texts.

Typical "Lordship" Statement #1: "Salvation requires works or obedience."

In other words, if works are not present as evidence of faith, it can be concluded that the individual is not saved. A key passage is Philippians 2:12, "Wherefore, my beloved, as ye have always obeyed, not as in my presence only, but now much more in my absence, work out your own salvation with fear and trembling." "Aha," proponents of Lordship Salvation would say, "Paul says 'work out your own salvation.'" Let us examine this statement. First of all, notice that Paul does not say, "work FOR your own salvation." No, he says "work OUT your own salvation." The sense of Verse twelve is the same as working out a mathematical problem. The idea Paul is conveying here is that those who have salvation WITHIN them should WORK IT OUT to its logical

conclusion. What is the logical conclusion of salvation? Look at the context. Philippians 2:5, "Let this mind be in you, which was also in Christ Jesus." What kind of mind (or attitude) did Christ have? It was an attitude that He, being in the form of God, thought it not robbery to be equal with God and humbled Himself and made Himself of no reputation. Paul is saying, "Let this kind of mind be in you." Be a humble person, be a godly person, be a holy person. This is the logical conclusion of salvation. Finally, when a believer does work that salvation out to its logical conclusion, it is actually God who does His work in us (Phil. 2:13).

Another passage, which is sometimes used to "prove" that Paul requires obedience for salvation, is II Thessalonians 1:7,8, "And to you who are troubled rest with us, when the Lord Jesus shall be revealed from Heaven with His mighty angels. In flaming fire taking vengeance on them that know not God, and that obey not the Gospel of our Lord Jesus Christ." The key here is to understand which coming of Christ is referred to in this text. Verse eight identifies it as the time when He comes in "flaming fire." This is not the Rapture, but the second coming. This takes place at the end of the Tribulation Period (see Rev. 19:11,12). Upon whom will Christ take vengeance? We who live in the Dispensation of Grace? No, Verse seven says we will "rest with us (Paul, Silas and Timothy)" when the Lord returns in flaming fire. Why are we resting? Because we will already be in Heaven having been raptured several years earlier. Those people who live through the tribulation period but refuse to obey the Gospel of the Lord Jesus Christ, which will be proclaimed at that time, will be the recipients of the "flaming fire." Which Gospel will be proclaimed during the Tribulation period? The Gospel of the Grace of God? No, the Gospel of the Kingdom (see Matt. 24:14-21). II Thessalonians 1:8 actually supports this teaching, and the fact that under the Kingdom Gospel, obedience is one of the requirements for salvation. Paul confirms it right here in this passage. So, rather than teaching that obedience is required for salvation today, Paul is actually teaching that obedience is required during the Tribulation period.

Some would point to Romans 1:5 as "proof" that Paul requires obedience as a requirement of salvation. "By whom we have received grace and apostleship, for obedience to the faith among all nations for His name." Also, Romans 6:17, "But God be thanked, that ye were the servants of sin**,** but ye have obeyed from the heart that form of doctrine which was delivered you." These and similar Pauline texts indeed show that God WANTS all men to obey Him and rejoices when they do. However, the obedience is not listed as a requirement or basis of salvation (as it is in Hebrews 5:9).

Typical "Lordship" Statement #2:
"Salvation requires continuing in the faith."

In other words, initial faith in the finished work of Christ is not enough: one must continue to believe in order to continue to be saved. Usually this is based on Matthew 24:13, "but he that endures to the end shall be saved." And again, we would point out that Matthew proclaims the Gospel of the Kingdom, which does indeed require continuation in faith. But does Paul teach the necessity of continuing in faith in order to be saved? Lordship Salvation proponents would say, "Yes," based on Paul's statement

in I Corinthians 15:1-2, "Moreover, brethren, I declare unto you the Gospel which I preached unto you, which also ye have received, and wherein ye stand; By which also ye are saved, if ye keep in memory what I preached unto you, unless ye have believed in vain." The key to these verses is to understand the Apostle Paul's practice of stating a positional truth and following it with a practical application. Nearly all of Paul's Epistles follow this pattern: the first half of the letter is doctrinal and the last half is practical application.

We find the same pattern here. Verse one is doctrinal and positional truth: "Moreover, brethren, I declare unto you the Gospel which I preached unto you, which also ye have received', and wherein ye stand" (I Cor. 15:1). This verse outlines the standing which the believer has before God simply by virtue of the fact that he has, by faith, received the Gospel. "Wherein ye stand" describes our position before a holy God. Verse two goes on to draw a practical application: "By which also ye are saved, if ye keep in memory what I preached unto you, unless ye have believed in vain." The key here is to understand that the word, "saved" can refer to spiritual salvation but it also can refer to the practical outworking and benefits of living for the Lord. For example, when Paul writes in I Timothy 2:15 about women being "saved in childbearing." Does he mean that by having babies women can get to Heaven? No, absolutely not. In the context, Paul is referring to being saved, or delivered from the pitfalls of confusing God's order for the sexes. The Apostle Paul is simply saying, that God's will for ladies is not to be teachers of men (I Tim. 2:12), but to "marry, bear children, guide the house" (I Tim. 5:14), and in doing so, they can save themselves a lot of headaches and a lot of problems.

If anyone needed that practical "salvation" or deliverance from their own vices, it was the Corinthian believers. Interestingly, Paul does not question their salvation. He calls them saints" in I Corinthians I:2, and tells them, "But ye are washed, but ye are sanctified, but ye are justified in the name of the Lord Jesus, and by the Spirit of our God" (I Cor. 6:11). Yet, he also calls them "carnal" (fleshly), and in danger of losing their rewards (yet not their salvation) (I Cor. 3:15).

In the context of I Corinthians, these believers needed deliverance from an error which had caused them much grief. Someone had convinced them that there was no resurrection (I Cor. 15:12). This was responsible for causing much of the bad conduct in this church (see Vss. 32 & 33). The way to be saved from these problems was to return to the doctrine which they had believed in the first place: the resurrection of Christ. This is also true for men and women today. Believing the Gospel initially will give them a standing before God; but continuing to hold to the principles of the Gospel will result in practical benefits in the daily life of the child of God.

Another Pauline text used to "prove" the necessity of continuing in faith is Colossians 1:23, "If ye continue in the faith grounded and settled, and be not moved away from the hope of the Gospel, which ye have heard, and which was preached to every creature which is under Heaven; whereof I Paul am made a minister." Doesn't it sound like Paul is saying that in order to be saved one must keep believing and continue in the faith? Let us look at the context and notice two things. First of all, Paul is talking about those

who have already been reconciled, "And you, that were sometime alienated and enemies in your mind by wicked works, yet now hath He reconciled in the body of His flesh through death, to present you holy and unblamable and unreprovable in His sight" (Colossians 1:21,22). Notice what he is doing in Verse twenty-two. He is presenting those who are reconciled to the Father. This refers to the day when the Lord returns to gather the Body of Christ to Himself, and will present them to the Father. But Christ desires to present believers "holy and unblamable and unreprovable."

There is indeed a condition to being presented in this fashion. But the condition in Verse 23 is not a condition of whether or not someone gets into Heaven. It is a condition of how Christ will be able to present the believers. He will either be able to present them holy and unblamable or He will have to present them with sonic excess baggage of "wood, hay and stubble" (I Cor. 3:12b) which needs to be burned away at the Judgment Seat of Christ.

How can the believer be presented to the Father, "holy and unblamable and unreprovable in his sight"? Verse 23 answers, "If ye continue in the faith grounded and settled, and be not moved away from the hope of the Gospel, which ye have heard, and which was preached to every creature which is under Heaven; whereof I Paul am made a minister." In order to be presented to the Lord entirely pure, holy, and blameless, even in a practical sense, we must stay close, and continue in the faith as preached by the Apostle Paul. He even puts his name in there (by inspiration of the Holy Spirit) to make sure no one misses the point. We must stay true to the Gospel that was revealed to the Apostle Paul. We are sometimes asked, "Are you saying that only Grace believers are going to be in Heaven?" The answer is, "yes and no." No one will be in Heaven who does not believe the Gospel of grace. Yet, there are people that are not Grace believers, who, nevertheless, do preach faith in the finished work of Christ, even to the point of emphasizing the true Gospel as found in I Corinthians 15:3,4. We would joyfully acknowledge that if they are preaching this Gospel, and people are believing it without becoming encumbered with all of the other religious activities of our day, they are saved. They are going to get to Heaven, even though they do not understand the Mystery program, or the principles of "rightly dividing the Word of Truth." But to be presented "holy and unblamable and unreprovable in His sight," one must not be moved away from that Gospel that was proclaimed by the Apostle Paul.

Typical "Lordship" Statement #3:
"A sinful lifestyle proves a person is not saved."

This statement is based on such passages as I Corinthians 6:9,10, "Know ye not that the unrighteous shall not inherit the kingdom of God? Be not deceived: neither fornicators, nor idolaters, nor adulterers, nor effeminate, nor abusers of themselves with mankind, nor thieves, nor covetous, nor drunkards, nor revelers, nor extortioners, shall inherit the kingdom of God." Similar statements are found in Galatians 5:21 and Ephesians 5:5. Is Paul teaching that anyone who lives these kinds of lifestyles will not enter Heaven regardless of whether they have believed on Christ or not? This is what Lordship Salvationists contend.

To answer this contention, first consider what Paul writes in I Corinthians 15:50. "Now this I say, brethren, that flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God...." If those who live a sinful lifestyle are automatically precluded from entering Heaven, then so is everyone else, for we are all "flesh and blood." But someone will say, "God will change our bodies into spiritual bodies someday and we will no longer be flesh and blood." This is true! And likewise, believers who have fallen into a sinful lifestyle will be changed from that lifestyle before entering Heaven, even if it takes their death to do it! Indeed, there will be no "fornicators, idolaters, adulterers," etc. in Heaven.

Yet, surely, Paul means more than this in these texts. And in Romans 8:16,17 we find an important principle which will aid in understanding what 't means to "inherit the Kingdom of God." Notice the two-fold inheritance in this text, "The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit, that we are the children of God: And if children, then heirs; heirs of God..." (Rom. 8:16,17a). Here is the first aspect of our inheritance as believers: by virtue of the fact that we are children of God, we also become "heirs of God." That is, we will literally inherit God, or the privilege of being in His presence for all eternity. But Verse seventeen goes on to speak of a second aspect of our inheritance: "and joint-heirs with Christ; if so be that we suffer with Him, that we may be also glorified together" (Rom. 8:17b). Here is an inheritance which goes above and beyond merely getting into the presence of God (as if that weren't enough!).

This second aspect of our inheritance is conditional, not merely based on being a child of God. Paul says we get this second aspect of our inheritance, "if so be that we suffer with Him" (Rom. 8:17b). This is almost identical to Paul's statement in II Timothy 2:12, "If we suffer, we shall also reign with Him..... Here is the key to understanding what it means to inherit the Kingdom of God. The word, "kingdom" speaks of ruling and authority. And indeed, in eternity, Christ's ruling authority will be entrusted to certain saints and not to others. How will He decide who gets to rule, and who merely lives in His "heavenly kingdom"? "If we suffer, we shall also reign with Him" (II Tim. 2:12). There it is! Those who suffer get to reign. But what kind of suffering qualifies us to be a part of the "ruling class" in eternity? The Scriptures tell us, "Yea, and all that will LIVE GODLY in Christ Jesus shall suffer persecution" (II Tim. 3:12).

On the other hand, "thieves, covetous, drunkards," etc. will not "inherit the kingdom of God." That is, they will not participate in the ruling authority of God's Kingdom. This could be likened to monarchies in our world today. Many citizens live in the "kingdom" of, say, Great Britain, Saudi Arabia or Jordan, but only the ruling class "Inherit the kingdom" as the monarchs pass off the scene. Are we saying all who live sinful lifestyles will "get to Heaven anyway"? No, of course not. Many (perhaps most) who live such blatant lives of sin are not saved to begin with. So it is obvious that these will not "Inherit the Kingdom of God." They will not even be citizens of Heaven, much less be a part of the ruling class. However, when a true child of God falls into a sinful lifestyle, it does not mean he will not get into Heaven (if he has genuinely trusted Christ as his personal Savior), but it does mean he will not "Inherit the Kingdom of God" as a co-regent with Christ. Perhaps Ephesians 5:5 states this principle a bit more clearly

than the other similar texts: "For this ye know, that no whoremonger, nor unclean person, nor covetous man, who is an idolater, hath any inheritance in the Kingdom of Christ and of God." Again, this verse does not say that one who has believed but then lives a life of sin will not get into Heaven. But it does say that this person will not have any inheritance there.

This is exactly what Paul means in I Corinthians 3:15, "If any man's work shall be burned, he shall suffer loss: BUT HE HIMSELF SHALL BE SAVED; yet so as by fire." The true believer, who has not lived for the Lord, will indeed be saved, but will have no rewards to show for a life of faithful service. Neither will he have the privilege of "reigning with Christ."

Another Pauline passage used to show that "a sinful lifestyle proves that a person is not saved," is Galatians 6:7,8. "Be not deceived; God is not mocked: for whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap. For he that soweth to his flesh shall of the flesh reap corruption', but he that soweth to the Spirit shall of the Spirit reap life everlasting." "See," the Lordship Salvationist cries, "There is no eternal life if someone sows to the flesh!"

Here is a classic case of taking a verse out of context. Paul is not speaking here of living a sinful life in the flesh. He dealt with that back in Galatians 5:17-21. In Galatians 6:16, Paul has begun a new context, which deals with the financial support of servants of God. "Let him that is taught in the word communicate (Paul's word for financial support - see Philippians 4:15,16) unto him that teacheth in all good things" (Gal. 6:16). In other words, "Pay the Preacher!" Then in Verses seven and eight, Paul illustrates what one reaps if he sows his finances to the flesh or to the Spirit. Money sown to the flesh reaps corruption: a rusty car, a ramshackled house, clothes which wear out and go out of style. But the one who sows his money to the Lord's work reaps a harvest of eternal life (not for himself) as others are saved. While it is true that sowing a sinful lifestyle will also iII results, this simply is not Paul's point in this context. Furthermore, whenever Paul uses the imagery of "sowing and reaping," it is in the context of how we use our finances (see I Cor. 9:11; II Cor. 9:6,7).

The Apostle of Grace is clear: a believer who lives a sinful lifestyle will suffer great loss at the judgment seat of Christ, "but he himself shall be saved" (I Cor. 3:15).

Typical "Lordship" Statement #4:
"Salvation WILL BE manifested by good works
(or fruit)"

This statement is usually based on Matthew 7:16-20, "Ye shall know them by their fruits ... Wherefore by their fruits shall ye know them." Once again, we agree that under the Jewish/Covenant system, God indeed required works or fruit as evidence of faith. But of course, the Lordship Salvationist desires to support this teaching from Paul's Epistles.

One passage used to do so is I Timothy 5:25, "Likewise also the good works of some are manifest beforehand; and they that are otherwise cannot be hid." This verse actually teaches that some men's good works will not be manifest beforehand (i.e., before they get to judgment). The preceding verse gives the other side of the coin, as it speaks of unbelievers: "Some men's sins are open beforehand, going before to judgment; and some men they follow after." Paul's whole point here is that one cannot always tell an unbeliever from a believer in this life, because sins and good works are not always manifest before judgment.

Another classic Pauline passage used to "prove" that salvation will always be manifested by fruit is Galatians 5-22,23. "But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, gentleness, goodness, faith, meekness, temperance: against such there is no law." But is Paul teaching that ALL Christians automatically exhibit the "fruit of the Spirit"? No, for two verses later, Paul writes, "If we live in the Spirit, let us also walk in the Spirit" (Gal. 5:25). If all true Christians always exhibited the fruit of the Spirit, why would the injunction of Verse twenty-five even be necessary? Paul is clearly distinguishing here between those who "live in the Spirit" (all who are saved), and those who "walk in the Spirit" (the saved who also yield to the Holy Spirit in their lives). The fruit of the Spirit is manifested by those who are saved AND are yielded to the Spirit and, therefore, "walk in the Spirit."

Typical "Lordship" Statement #5:
"Salvation requires total surrender to the Lordship of Christ."

This statement is based on two key Pauline texts which are admittedly very important to our discussion. The first is I Corinthians 12:3, "Wherefore I give you to understand, that no man speaking by the Spirit of God calleth Jesus accursed: and that no man can say that Jesus is the Lord, but by the Holy Ghost." Truly, this verse teaches that believers have a unique understanding of who Jesus Christ is. The whole point of this verse is to show that the believer has an ability that is not shared by unbelievers; that is, the believer "can say that Jesus is the Lord." Paul is not simply saying only believers can frame these words; a parrot could be taught to say them. But only a true believer who understands who Jesus Christ is, can say from the heart that "Jesus is Lord." But just because we "can" affirm this truth, does not mean we always do (even though we should).

A similar passage says, "That if thou shalt confess with thy mouth the Lord Jesus, and shalt believe in thine heart that God hath raised Him from the dead, thou shalt be saved" (Rom. 10:9). Again, the "Lordship" proponents read more into this verse than is actually there. The broader context of Romans Chapters nine, ten and eleven deals with Israel's rejection of Christ: "Brethren, my heart's desire and prayer to God for Israel is, that they might be saved. For I bear them God for Israel is, that they might be saved. For I bear them record that they have a zeal of God, but not according to knowledge. For they being ignorant of God's righteousness, and going about to establish their own righteousness, have not submitted themselves unto the righteousness of God. For

CHRIST is the end of the Law for righteousness to every one that belleveth" (Rom. 10:1-4). The issue for Israel, concerning Christ, was, "Whom do men say that I the Son of man am?" (Matt. 16:13). He was not "John the Baptist, Elijah, Jeremiah or one of the prophets." He was "the Christ, the Son of the living God" (Matt. 16:16).

Therefore, when Paul brings up Christ's Lordship in the context of Israel's rejection of Christ, as he does in Romans ten, the reference is obviously to the person of Christ as Lord, not the actions of those who believe. We are saved by faith in the finished work of Christ: the true Christ who is Lord of all!

Those who would make Paul a preacher of "Lordship Salvation," as proclaimed by many modem Bible teachers, are guilty of twisting Paul's Epistles to their own destruction (II Pet. 3:16).

Typical "Lordship" Statement #6:
"Salvation requires repentance from sin."

Once again, we affirm the fact that repentance is a major component in the preaching of John the Baptist, Christ and the Twelve Apostles. "In those days came John the Baptist, preaching in the wilderness of Judea, And saying, Repent; for the Kingdom of Heaven is at hand" (Matt. 3:1,2). "From that time Jesus began to preach, and to say, Repent; for the Kingdom of Heaven is at hand" (Matt. 4:17). "Then Peter said unto them, Repent, and be baptized, every one of you, in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins..." (Acts 2:38). Israel was God's chosen people who had turned from the covenant He made with them. Even though they had departed from God, they were still a covenant people. They still believed in God; their main need was to return to the covenant. Therefore, the main emphasis of the Kingdom Gospel was to "repent." Israel was going the wrong direction and needed to turn around.

Does Paul preach the necessity of repentance for salvation? He certainly mentions repentance, especially during his journeys as recorded in Acts (see 17:30; 20:21; 26:20). While some have suggested that during this time Paul preached a Kingdom Gospel much like the other Apostles, and, therefore, emphasizes repentance, we reject this view in the light of his clear preaching of justification by faith without the Law in Acts 13:38,39. Why does Paul preach repentance if salvation is by faith alone (Acts 16:31)? The answer is two-fold:

First, the word "repentance" literally means to have "a change of mind" (Gk. "metanoia" - "another mind"). Indeed, when one believes in Christ, he has a change of mind about the Savior. Before salvation, a person may be opposed to Christianity, or just neutral, or ignorant of the saving work of Christ. But when he believes on Christ, a great change of mind takes place. So in this sense, it is true that one "repents" when they believe on Christ; they now have "another mind" about Him.

A second observation is that it is entirely appropriate to preach repentance in this Dispensation of Grace, as a proper response to God. As Paul testifies before King

Agrippa, he states how he "showed first unto them of Damascus, and at Jerusalem, and throughout all the coasts of Judea, that they should repent and turn to God, and do works meet for repentance" (Acts 26:20). And indeed, we affirm that all mankind "should repent (have a change of mind) and turn to God." And having done so, they should "do works meet (fitting) for repentance." This is entirely consistent with Paul's later admonition "that they who have believed in God might be careful to maintain good works" (Titus 3:8).

None of Paul's references to repentance, however, change the clear fact that in this Dispensation of Grace, salvation is "by grace through FAITH," and "not of works, lest any man should boast" (Eph. 2:8,9).

PART THREE
ANSWERING LORDSHIP SALVATION

CHAPTER 6
"THE ACCUSATIONS OF LORDSHIP SALVATION"

Those who would preach the Grace of God, as Paul did, can expect to be misrepresented as he was so often. "Lordship" proponents level at least four major accusations against those who preach that faith alone in the finished work of Christ is enough for salvation.

"Encouraging Sin"

The first accusation against true "Grace preaching" is: "You are encouraging sin." Or, to put it in the form of a question, "If you preach that good works are unnecessary for salvation, what's to keep people from living in sin?" Now, let's think about this question for a moment. What is it really saying? This question clearly suggests that the only way to keep Christians from living a sinful life, is to hold over their heads the possibility that they just "might not make it" if they do not "straighten up." This is, of course, simply a case of reverting to the doctrine of salvation by works. The true method for living a holy life in this Dispensation of Grace will be examined later, but suffice it to say, it is not through the threat of not making it to Heaven!

This accusation that "Grace preaching" encourages sin, illustrates the attraction which Lordship Salvation teaching holds for many people. That is**,** many are weary of seeing countless church goers, who profess to be saved, yet live in blatant worldly fashion. While this should trouble all of us, let us not rush to another dispensation for a solution when God has a perfectly good one for us today in the Pauline revelation.

You see, the accusation that Grace preaching encourages sin is nothing new. Paul was accused of the very same thing! After explaining that "where sin abounded, grace did much more abound" (Romans 5:20), Paul anticipates and quickly answers the question,

"What shall we say then? Shall we continue in sin, that grace may abound? God forbid. How shall we that are dead to sin, live any longer in it?" (Rom. 6:1,2). It should serve to reassure us that we who preach the pure grace of God, get the same reaction that Paul did: it puts us in pretty good company!

"Cheap Grace"

A second accusation against Grace preaching is: "You are preaching cheap Grace." What, may we ask, is "cheap Grace"? We do not mind being ridiculed for our beliefs, but to call Grace "cheap" is a direct insult to God, and in particular, to the perfect work performed by Jesus Christ at Calvary! Grace is not "cheap;" it is "FREE." There is a big difference between the two! If someone were to offer you a Rolls Royce automobile as a gift, would that make it "cheap?" No, getting a Rolls Royce for free would not diminish the fact that it is still a very expensive, handcrafted, quality automobile. The Grace which is offered to us was actually very expensive to God. How much did Grace cost? "For ye know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that, though He was rich, yet for your sakes He became poor, that ye through His poverty might be rich" (II Cor. 8:9). Offering Grace at no cost to us was the most expensive thing God ever did: it cost Him the life of His only Begotten Son. Let us never call this "cheap Grace!"

"Easy Believism"

A third accusation against Grace preaching is that we preach "easy believism." Again, we're not sure what this is supposed to mean, but we ask you: Is it easy to believe that a Man who lived two-thousand years ago, Whom we have never seen, died and rose from the dead, and that this is supposed to save us? We submit to our readers that this is not all that easy to believe, and in fact, without a divine revelation from God in the form of the Holy Scriptures, no one would believe it! For "faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the Word of God" (Rom. 10:17). Yet, on the other hand, we would joyfully affirm that it is easy to be saved! That is, it is easy for us. All we need to do is believe; it is God who did the hard part.

"Antinomianism"

A fourth accusation leveled at Grace preaching is, "You are antinomian." When we first heard this one, this writer reacted with a hearty, "No we're not!" You see, most of us have the wrong notion of what "Antinomianism" actually is. Many folks think Antinomianism means to be lawless, for the root meaning of the word is literally "no law." But upon further investigation, Webster's Dictionary defines an antinomian as "a believer in the doctrine that faith alone, not obedience to the moral Law, is necessary for salvation" (Webster's New World Dictionary, Second College Edition). If this is what an antinomian is, then we should gladly wear the label, for we strongly affirm that the requirement for salvation is indeed "faith alone, not obedience to the moral Law. "

And, of course, this is exactly what Paul taught: "Knowing that a man is not Justified by the works of the Law, but by the faith of Jesus Christ, even we have believed in Jesus

Christ, that we might be justified by the faith of Christ, and not by the works of the Law: for by the works of the Law shall no flesh be justified" (Gal. 2:16). And furthermore, Paul writes, "All things are lawful for me, but all things are not expedient: all things are lawful for me, but all things edify not" (II Cor. 10:23). This is Grace living! Quite frankly, some Christians seem to have a hard time handling Grace, for it puts the responsibility for many of the decisions of life squarely upon them. Many would rather live under the Law, for then every decision is made for them. Under Grace, the Lord wants us to do the night thing, but He wants it to be because we freely choose to do so, not because we were coerced into it by a heavy-handed Law.

CHAPTER 7
"MAJOR PROBLEMS OF LORDSHIP SALVATION"

Solomon's words of some three-thousand years ago still ring true today: "there is no new thing under the sun" (Eccl. 1:9). This is true of the Lordship Salvation teaching. Just as the Judaizers of Paul's day tried to superimpose Jewish requirements and works as a part of salvation (Acts 15:1), so today men still attempt to associate a requirement of works as evidence of genuine faith. The current manifestation of Lordship Salvation is, in a sense, still under development. And as any theological trend develops, certain characteristics become evident. In this chapter, we shall examine some of the major doctrinal problems which have arisen as a result of "Lordship" teachers attempting to be consistent with their own theology.

Retreat from Dispensationalism

The first problem of Lordship Salvation doctrine is that it represents a retreat from dispensationalism. As a rule, those who are speaking out against modern "Lordship" teachings are dispensationalists. On the other hand, the most vocal proponents of Lordship Salvation are either weak in their dispensational position, or are out and out Covenant Theologlans. One of the most popular proponents of Lordship Salvation began his ministry as a fairly strong (albeit, Acts 2) dispensationalist. However, as time progressed, he began emphasizing the Four Gospels more heavily than the Pauline Epistles. The first step in this direction was a message series entitled, "Kingdom Living Today," based on the Sermon on the Mount. Traditionally, it was the Modernists who attempted to apply the Sermon on the Mount to today, and the Fundamentalists who recognized these truths as a part of the Jewish program ("the meek shall inherit the earth" - Matt. 5:5, etc.).

Next, this popular speaker and writer penned, "The Gospel According to Jesus." This, of course, showed a lack of recognition of the Gospel of the Kingdom as being distinct from the Gospel of the Grace of God.

All of this shows weakness and inconsistency of Acts 2 dispensationalism. If Paul is merely an extension of the Twelve Apostles, or at least if he taught the same Gospel, then we must go back to "the Gospel according to Jesus," as He preached it while on

the earth. The solution to this is to recognize that Christ made a new revelation to the Apostle of the Gentiles, no longer as the lowly Man from Galilee, but as the glorified Lord of Heaven. Failure to distinguish between the "Twelve" and Paul has not only lead to "Lordship" teaching, it has also opened the road for the Charismatic infiltration into traditionally fundamental churches. After all, if the Church, the Body of Christ began in Acts 2 under Peter and the Twelve, is it not reasonable to expect to see the signs which were promised under their commission (Mark 16:15-18)? Remember, it was Paul who said that "tongues" would "cease" (I Cor. 13:8). And it was through Paul that Christ revealed the marvelous truth of justification by faith without the works of the Law (Acts 13:39, etc.)

Refusal to recognize the uniqueness of Paul's God-given ministry and message, must of necessity result in at least one of two things: either Paul's "no works" Gospel must be twisted to conform with the Gospel of the Kingdom (which requires works as a show of faith), or, the Gospel of the Kingdom, preached by Christ and the Twelve (and James) must be twisted to remove the works' requirements which it so clearly contains (Matt. 19:17; Acts 2:38; James 2:24, etc. - see Appendix 4). We recommend doing neither. Instead, rightly divide" the Word of Truth (II Tim. 2:15) and no Scripture needs to be twisted at all!

Grace and Works

A second problem of Lordship Salvation is that it compromises the clear Pauline distinction between Grace and works. "And if by grace, then it is no more of works: otherwise Grace is no more Grace. But if it be of works, then it is no more Grace: otherwise work is no more work" (Rom. 11:6). But do works have a place in the Christian life? Of course they do! Paul makes this clear in many passages (see Chapter 8). But the difference between Paul and "Lordship" teaching is this: "Lordship" doctrine says, "faith MUST be accompanied by works," but Paul says, "faith SHOULD be followed by good works." Hear these majestic words: "For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: Not of works, lest any man should boast" (Eph. 2:8,9). But Paul does not stop there, he goes on to show the place of works: "For we are His workmanship, created in Christ Jesus UNTO good works, which God hath before ordained that we SHOULD walk in them" (Eph. 2:10). We simply feel that the Lordship doctrine has gotten the "cart before the horse," or as one Brother has so eloquently put it, they "put the horse in the cart."

Admonitions to Christians

A third major problem of Lordship Salvation is that it ignores exhortations to Christians to present themselves to the Lord. In the Book of Romans, Paul writes to the "saints" (Rom. 1:7) who are members of the Body of Christ (12:5), yet he exhorts them, "I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that ye present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable unto God, which is your reasonable service" (Rom. 12:1). If salvation requires that a person totally "submit to the Lordship of Christ," as Lordship proponents insist, then Paul’s words to believers to present their bodies to the

Lord are meaningless. Why would he have to exhort them to do something that they already did in order to be saved in the first place?

What is Carnality?

A fourth problem of Lordship Salvation is that it falls to explain the meaning of "carnality." Writing to the Corinthians, Paul stated, "For ye are yet carnal (fleshly)" (I Cor. 3:3). Yet, as with the Romans, Paul refers to the Corinthians as saints" (I Cor. 1:2). If "Lordship" doctrine were true, there could be no such thing as a "carnal" Christian, for carnality would prove that the person was not a Christian at all. But Paul makes it clear that it is possible to be saved, yet not be living for the Lord. In fact, he illustrates this right in the Book of I Corinthians.

One illustration Paul gives of a believer who is saved, but has no good works to show it, is found in I Corinthians 3:11-15. In Verse eleven, Paul writes, "For no other foundation can no man lay than that is laid, which is Jesus Christ." Here is our salvation: being built on the foundation of Jesus Christ. But once on that foundation, the next step is to build. "Now if any man build upon this foundation gold, silver, precious stones, wood, hay, stubble..." (I Cor. 3:12). Here are the "works" performed as Christians. Some works are good: gold, silver and precious stones. Some works are bad: wood, hay and stubble. "Every man's work shall be made manifest: for the day shall declare it, because it shall be revealed by fire; and the fire shall try every man's work of what sort it is. If any man's work abide which he hath built thereupon, he shall receive a reward" (Vss. 13 & 14). But what happens if a man's work does not survive the fire of the judgment seat of Christ? What if a Christian has absolutely no good works to his name, no fruit which would show he was faithful? "Lordship" doctrine would have to conclude the man was not really saved. But what does Paul say, by inspiration of the Holy Spirit? Listen to his words: "If any man's work shall be burned, he shall suffer loss: BUT HE HIMSELF SHALL BE SAVED; yet so as by fire" (I Cor. 3:15). Here is the ultimate end of a carnal Christian! He arrives at Heaven, but has no rewards. "Lordship" doctrine has no explanation of how this can be.

Another illustration of one who is saved, yet is not in submission to the Lordship of Christ, is found two chapters later. "It is reported commonly that there is fornication among you, and such fornication as is not so much as named among the Gentiles, that one should have his father's wife" (I Cor. 5: 1). This man was blatantly living in a sinful, incestuous relationship. Again, judging by "Lordship" doctrine, this man could not possibly be saved. Yet Paul, who recognized him as a "brother" (see vs. 11), instructed the church "To deliver such an one unto Satan for the destruction of the flesh, THAT THE SPIRIT MAY BE SAVED in the day of the Lord Jesus" (I Cor. 5:5).

Assurance of Salvation

A fifth major problem of Lordship Salvation is that it can never truly provide the Christian with an assurance of salvation. A question which "Lordship" proponents cannot satisfactorily answer is, "How can I know for sure that I am saved." To this, they may

respond, "You know you are saved if your life shows evidence of salvation." Then, the next logical question is, "How good must I be, and for how long, before I know I am saved?" To this they have no answer. Tragically, this view often leads, not to a bold confidence of salvation which is founded firmly on what Christ has done, but, rather, to cowering Christians who are never quite sure if they are going to make it. Which kind of Christian do you suppose Satan would rather see? And which kind of Christian is going to be more apt to proclaim to others that they, too, can know for sure that they are saved?

On what basis should the Christian have assurance of salvation? On the basis of the clear teaching of the Word of God! And what does God's Word say to us today? "That we should be to the praise of His glory, who first trusted in Christ; In whom ye also trusted, after ye heard the Word of Truth, the Gospel of your salvation; in whom also after ye believed, YE WERE SEALED WITH THAT HOLY SPIRIT of promise, Who is the earnest of our inheritance until the redemption of the purchased possession, unto the praise of His glory" (Eph. 1:12-14). You can be sure of your salvation if you have "trusted in Christ" through believing "the Gospel of your salvation." Period! End of discussion!

Ironically, many Lordship Salvationists will say they believe that salvation is secure, and that those who are saved WILL do good works, because God will simply cause this to be. This reflects the Calvinist bent, which is typical of many "Lordship" proponents. When pressed as to whether they believe in eternal security, a true Calvinist will respond, "I believe in the perseverance of the saints." This means they believe God gives the initial faith to be saved, and continues to give faith to keep the person saved. This is NOT the doctrine of eternal security which Paul teaches in Ephesians 1:12-14 (see Appendix 2 for further discussion of the "Calvinist Connection" to Lordship Salvation teaching).

CHAPTER 8
"SOME FINAL QUESTIONS"

Perhaps the most troubling aspect of Lordship Salvation is that it presents an essentially different approach to salvation than does the Gospel of the Grace of God.

Can a "Lordship" Gospel Save?

The question then arises, "Can a person truly be saved under a 'Lordship' gospel?" It has been our observation that many believers have been exposed to this teaching AFTER they have trusted Christ. These, of course, are saved so long as they believed the Gospel for today (I Cor. 15:1-4). But what about those who are "evangelized" through a "Lordship gospel"?

First, God's Word is powerful in spite of us. "So shall My Word be that goeth forth out of My mouth; it shall not return unto Me void, but it shall accomplish that which I please, and it shall prosper in the thing whereto I sent it" (Isa. 55:11). We do not deny that

many "Lordship" teachers do preach the death of Christ as the payment for sin, and the fact that He rose from the grave. In fact, we rejoice when they do so! As Paul wrote, "Notwithstanding, every way, whether in pretense or in truth, Christ is preached; and in that I do rejoice, yea, and will rejoice" (Phil. 1:18). Does this mean Paul agreed with everything these preachers did and taught? Not at all! But when they preached Christ, he rejoiced, and so should we.

When the Word of God is preached, the Holy Spirit then has a tool to work with, for "faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the Word of God" (Rom. 10:17). He can convince the hearer of the truth of Christ's finished sacrifice on Calvary and their need to believe it. But do not forget that Satan is the great deceiver who tries to blind "the minds of them who believe not, lest the light of the glorious Gospel of Christ, who is the image of God, should shine unto them" (II Cor. 4:4). The truth is, most preaching throughout the centuries has been a mixture of Grace and the Kingdom Gospel, yet it appears that at least some people are saved under this preaching. But let it be clear: anyone saved in this dispensation is saved by believing the Gospel of the Grace of God, not through trusting in baptism, repentance, good works, or any other element of the Kingdom Gospel. Unfortunately, Lordship Salvation clouds the shining light of the Grace of God to the point that many folks simply never see it.

Another major concern with "Lordship" teaching is that many will reject God's Grace because they feel the requirements for salvation are simply too great. They may very well adopt the attitude, "You mean I have to totally change my lifestyle in order to be saved? Forget it!" But by the Grace of God, we have witnessed the joy of seeing a sinner trust Christ and THEN become convicted of their sinful lifestyle as the Holy Spirit ministers to them. One of the blessings of the pure Grace of God is that He meets us right where we are, and accepts us not on our merits, but on the merits of Jesus Christ. This is why Paul could pen the wondrous words, "To the praise of the glory of His grace, wherein He hath made us accepted in the beloved" (Eph. 1:6).

To answer the question, "Can a person truly be saved under "'Lordship' gospel,'" we reply, "yes" and "no." "Yes" if they hear the part about Christ's perfect sacrifice on Calvary and simply trust in His finished work. But tragically, "no" if they have incorporated one "iota" of the excess baggage which most "Lordship" teachers attach to the Gospel as a requirement of faith.

Should Not Christ Be Lord?

A second question which any believer should sincerely ask, is, "Should not Christ BE LORD of every area of our lives?" And the answer is, "OF COURSE HE SHOULD!" But this submission should be as a willing RESPONSE to salvation, not as a requirement for salvation. We are convinced that it is this very lack of submission to the Lordship of Christ in the lives of so many believers, which has led to the reaction known as "Lordship Salvation." But the solution to this problem is not to go back under the Law or Kingdom Gospel. Rather, the solution is to understand how God has designed the Grace of God to be sufficient for living the Christian life.

"How Should We Then Live"?

This leads to a third, related question. "How can the believer under Grace live a consistent Christian life under the Lordship of Jesus Christ?" The Pauline Epistles are filled with answers to this question, but the most complete discussion of this important area of the faith is found in Romans Chapter six. Romans six is a discourse on "sanctification," or, simply: how to live a holy life. In this chapter, Paul asks and answers two questions about sin. These two questions are found in Verses 1 and 15. The first question deals with our POSITION in Christ, and the second question deals with our PRACTICE as Christians. Verse I asks, "Shall we continue IN SIN...," that is, shall we continue to live under sin's dominion now that we have a new position of being "in Christ?" The answer, of course, is "NO! NEVER." Verse 15 asks, "shall we sin..... that is, shall we commit personal sin, because we are under Grace? Again, the answer is "NO!" because we now have a choice, as believers, of whom we want to serve. The entire chapter can be outlined as follows:

1A. The Positional Side of Sanctification Vss. 1-14
- 1B. Identification Vss. 1-10
- 2B. Imputation ("Reckoning") Vss. 11-13

- Conclusion: vs. 14

2A. The Practical Side of Sanctification Vss. 15-19
- 1B. The Principle Vss. 15,16
- 2B. The Practice Vss. 17-19

- Conclusion: Vss. 20-23

Let us briefly observe Paul's argument for holy living. It begins with a recognition of our union with Christ. It is tragic indeed that most denominations have "watered down" Romans Chapter six, for in doing so, they have obscured one of the most blessed truths of the Christian life: that is**,** our identification with Christ. Being "baptized into Jesus Christ" (Rom. 6:3) refers to our union with Christ, not a water ceremony. The basic meaning of the word "baptize" (Gk. baptizo) is "to identify." This can be illustrated from I Corinthians 10:1,2 where Paul states that the Israelites were "baptized unto Moses..... This means they were identified with Moses in all his experiences in the wilderness. Likewise, when we trust Christ, we become identified with Him in His experiences, namely, His death, burial and resurrection.

What does being identified with His death, burial and resurrection have to do with holiness? Paul explains: "Know ye not, that so many of us as were baptized (identified) into Jesus Christ were baptized (identified) into his death?" (Rom. 6:3). We died with Christ, and, therefore, died to the rulership of sin. We no longer belong to the slave-master called "SIN." Next, "Therefore we are buried with Him by baptism (identification) into death..." (Rom. 6:4a): that is, our sins were placed into the grave with Him and put out of God's sight. Finally, "like as Christ was raised up from the dead by the glory of the Father, even so we also SHOULD WALK IN NEWNESS OF LIFE" (Rom. 6:4b).

Let us illustrate: imagine yourself a slave, laboring under a cruel slave-master who continually whips and beats you. Finally, one day you die. Miraculously, you come back to life only to find that you are still a slave. But something is different now. Your new slave-master is kind and generous. He still expects your service, but rewards you richly and treats you well. Incredibly, you learn that your new Slavemaster lives across the road from the old one. Your new master tells you that even though you belong to him, you are now free. You now have a choice: continue to serve the new Master or go back and work for the old. Of course, to a Spirit-filled believer, this is not a choice at all. Who would want to go back to a cruel slave-master?

Next, the Apostle illustrates how a believer should handle the beckoning of the old master, sin, as he calls over the fence to serve him. Verse 11, "Likewise reckon ye also yourselves to be dead indeed unto sin..... Remember, you died to sin's rulership, and you no longer have to serve sin; therefore, when temptation comes, consider yourself a lifeless corpse, and respond to sin as a corpse would. A story is told of two young ladies who trusted Christ. Soon afterwards, they were invited to a party by some of their old friends. Knowing that the party would include drinking and drugs, the young ladies returned a card stating: "We cannot accept your invitation, because we died two weeks ago." They had learned to "reckon themselves dead indeed unto sin!"

We who preach the Dispensation of the Grace of God are often accused of encouraging sin. It is interesting and instructive that in the midst of a discussion on holiness, the inspired Apostle states: "For sin shall not have dominion over you: for ye are not under the Law, but under Grace" (Rom. 6:14). Far from encouraging sin, Grace is the basis for avoiding sin! In Verse 16, Paul expounds the principle of yielding our members to God. "Know ye not, that to whom ye yield yourselves servants to obey, His servants ye are to whom ye obey; whether of sin unto death, or of obedience unto righteousness? By "members," Paul simply means the members of our body: our eyes, ears, hands, feet, etc. This is the principle that righteous Job learned thousands of years ago: "I made a covenant with mine eyes; why then should I think upon a maid?"

Note that in Verse 16, Paul is not contrasting death and life, but rather, death and righteousness. This is because in Verses 15-19, he is dealing with the practical ramifications of obeying sin or obeying righteousness. Continuing in sin as a believer can lead to physical death (I Cor. 5:5; 11:29,30); but obeying God leads to practical sanctification, or personal righteousness (Vss. 17-19).

In the remainder of Romans Chapter six (Vss. 20-23), Paul contrasts the two positions of being under the servitude of sin versus being under the servitude of God. Sin's rulership results in shame and death, but God's rulership results in holiness and life. The whole point of Romans six is, "If you are a part of Christ, then act like it by yielding to God." All of this, of course, must be done through the power of the Holy Spirit in the life of the believer.

Another major passage dealing with the subject of spiritual living is found in the Book of Galatians. Here, the Apostle contrasts the Spirit and the flesh (Gal. 5:6-25). The key to this passage is found at the end of this section: "If we live in the Spirit, let us also walk in the Spirit" (Gal. 5:25). This verse teaches us that it is possible to "live" in the Spirit (salvation) without "walking" in the Spirit (sanctification). Otherwise, why would Paul be admonishing us to "walk in the Spirit" (Vs. 16)? Again, "Lordship" doctrine cannot conceive of such a thing, since it teaches that salvation requires total submission to the Lordship of Christ. If all believers automatically walked according to the Spirit, either as a requirement, or as a result of salvation, then it would not be necessary for Paul to admonish us to do so; but he does, and in so doing, he provides us with an important key to the Christian life.

In Galatians 5:17, Paul describes the "war within" which wages in the life of every believer. It is the struggle between the Spirit and the flesh. As a believer in Christ, you are a new creature" in Christ (II Cor. 5:17). But this does not mean that sin is eradicated from your life. Sin is still very much alive and well, and resides in what the Scriptures term, "the flesh." But as a child of God, you also have the Holy Spirit within you (Rom. 8:9; I Cor. 6:19). Paul tells us that "the flesh lusteth (lit. 'wars') against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh" (Gal. 5:17a). The key here is to recognize that it is not our job to battle the flesh. When we do so, we lose. We need to get out of the way and let the Spirit fight the flesh, for He will win! Once again, this is accomplished when we "yield" ourselves to God (Rom. 6:13). When we do so, the Spirit produces "fruit" in our lives (Gal. 5:22,23).

In Romans 12:1,2 we find a lesson in the Grace of God. Here, Paul literally begs, "I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that ye present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable unto God, which is your reasonable service. And be not conformed to this world, but be ye transformed by the renewing of your mind, that ye may prove what is that good, and acceptable, and perfect will of God." Once more, we ask, if total submission to the Lordship of Christ is a requirement for salvation in the first place, why is Paul begging the "brethren" to present their bodies to God'? Paul realizes that under grace, salvation is by faith alone, and that works have no part (Rom. 4:4,5). Therefore he resorts to "begging" (this is the meaning of "beseech") us to present our bodies to God. This is to be done, not as a requirement for salvation, but as our "reasonable" service (or, literally, "worship"). After all, Christ gave His life for us; is it not reasonable to present our bodies back to Him or His use? Yes it is!

The simple fact is, Christians need constant reminding to serve God. This is why the Apostle writes, "This is a faithful saying, and these things I will that thou affirm constantly, that they who have believed in God might be careful to maintain good works" (Titus 3:8a). Why? So we might be saved? No! Salvation is settled back in Verse 5: "Not by works of righteousness which we have done, but according to His mercy He saved us, by the washing of regeneration, and the renewing of the Holy Ghost" (Titus 3:5). Why, then does Paul admonish us to maintain good works? He answers in the rest of Verse 8: "These things are good and profitable unto men. "

We who stand firmly upon the Gospel of the Grace of God should be examples of that Grace, "For the Grace of God that bringeth salvation hath appeared to all men, Teaching us that, denying ungodliness and worldly lusts, WE SHOULD LIVE SOBERLY, RIGHTEOUSLY, AND GODLY IN THIS PRESENT WORLD" (Titus 2:11,12). Let us not give the critics an occasion to malign the preaching of the pure Grace of God!

APPENDICES

In these appendices, I will include first-person observations and further discussion of pertinent issues related to the "Lordship" controversy. My aim is to shed further light on difficult questions and attempt to clarify any misunderstanding the reader may have about my own personal views on various subjects.

Appendix I – "Weren't men always saved by faith without works?"

Dispensationalists (even the "Acts 2" variety) have long been accused of teaching that Old Testament saints were saved by works. While I cannot speak for all others, I have never believed nor taught this. I did not teach this when I was an Acts 2 dispensationalist, and I do not teach it now that I am a Mid-Acts dispensationalist. Works never saved anyone in any dispensation. But, (let us say it again) under the Jewish program, works demonstrated one's faith. That is, if God revealed to a person that they should offer an animal sacrifice to cover their sins, what would a believing person do? Right! Offer an animal sacrifice. Would the act of offering the sacrifice save them? No! But by the same token, the person who refused to offer the sacrifice demonstrated, by his refusal to obey God, that he did not believe what God said. If he believed God, he would have offered the sacrifice. Therefore, we could say that Old Testament people were not saved by works, but neither were they saved without them, for the works proved that they had faith (which is the essential element for salvation in any dispensation).

To answer the question, "Weren't men always saved by faith without works?" we answer with a resounding "NO!" Else, why did Paul write the majestic words, "BUT NOW the righteousness of God WITHOUT (apart from) the Law is manifested, being witnessed by the Law and the prophets" (Rom. 3:21). If the words, "But now" do not indicate a change, then what do they indicate? Paul is obviously drawing a marked contrast between how men obtained righteousness previous to this dispensation, and how righteousness is obtained now. Previous to this age, the righteousness of God involved faithful obedience to the Law. BUT NOW, the righteousness of God involves faith alone, WITHOUT THE LAW (see Rom. 3:28),

Yet some would argue, "Doesn't Paul say that this righteousness without the Law is witnessed by the Law and the prophets?" The answer, of course, is, yes, he does. There are two ways we could take the phrase, "witnessed by the Law and the prophets." The first way is to take this simply in the sense that the Law and the prophets are being personified; that is, Paul is portraying the Law and the prophets as standing

by (in awe), witnessing this great change in God's dealings with mankind. The second (and most common) way of taking this statement is in the sense of the Law and the prophets themselves holding examples of being justified without the Law.

For the sake of argument, let us say that this second interpretation of "being witnessed by the Law and the prophets" is correct. Does this mean that justification was always obtained by faith without the deeds of the Law? Again, we point to the first two words of Romans 3:21, "BUT NOW." It is obvious that a contrast is being drawn, no matter how one interprets the rest of the verse. Yet if Paul is saying that the Law and the prophets also give examples of this kind of "faith without law" justification, we must examine the context of these examples to find out what they are teaching. It may be that this is what Paul is doing in Romans Chapter four. There, he gives two examples of men who received imputed righteousness apart from the Law: Abraham (or, more correctly, Abram), and David. Let us consider each of these examples.

First, Paul writes, "What shall we say, then, that Abraham, our father, as pertaining to the flesh, hath found? For if Abraham were justified by works, he hath something of which to glory, but not before God. For what saith the Scripture? Abraham believed God, and it was counted unto him for righteousness" (Rom. 3:1-3). This example presents no problem whatsoever for our contention that "faith without the Law" justification is a contrast to the previous dispensation. That is because Paul is referring here to Abraham before his circumcision (well before the Law was given), and this is the whole point we have been making. Paul preached the Gospel of the "Uncircumcision"; that is, it is a Gospel which requires no work or ritual as a requirement or as a demonstration of faith, just like Abraham (actually "Abram") did not have to do any work in Genesis 15:5 when God promised him that his seed would be as numerous as the stars. Abram simply "believed in the LORD; and he counted it to him as righteousness" (Gen. 15:6). The observant student of Scripture will notice that the content of what Abram believed is different than the content of what we believe to be declared righteous. Abram believed the "Gospel" (good news) that he would have a large family. We believe the good news that Christ died for our sins, was buried and rose again the third day according to the Scriptures.

Incidentally, James uses Abraham to prove that justification is by works and not by faith only. "Was not Abraham, our father, justified by works, when he had offered Isaac, his son, upon the altar?" (James 2:21). How can Paul use Abraham justification by faith without works, yet James uses to prove Abraham to prove justification by works? Simple! Paul points to Abraham before he was circumcised (Gen. 15) and James points to Abraham after he was circumcised (Gen. 22). A great change in God's dealings with man occurred with the introduction of the "Covenant of Circumcision" (Acts 7:8)! From that point until the removal of circumcision (remember Paul's "Gospel of the UNcircumcision?"), God required some sort of ritual or work to show one's faith.

But what about the example of David? "Even as David describeth the blessedness of the man unto whom God imputeth righteousness without works, Saying, Blessed are they whose iniquities are forgiven, and whose sins are covered. Blessed is the man to

whom the Lord will not impute sin" (Rom. 4:6-8). Is Paul teaching here that David was justified in the identical manner that we are? I do not believe so. For one thing, David refers to sin being "covered." This is not a "Grace" or even a "New Testament" teaching. Sin being "covered" is strictly an Old Testament teaching which is known as "atonement." Before the sacrifice of Christ, sins were not taken away, only covered. The fact that this is mentioned in David's quotation shows that whatever Paul is illustrating, it is not that everything David is describing is identical to our experience under Grace. Furthermore, when David says, "Blessed is the man to whom the Lord will not impute sin," he is certainly not describing the normal experience of the Old Testament Israelite, for Paul states that "sin is not imputed WHEN THERE IS NO LAW" (Rom. 5:13). This clearly implies that sin IS imputed when there IS Law (i.e., the Law of Moses). So, at least in this case, we could say that what David is describing is an "exception to the rule" as far as sin not being imputed under the Law. And this is exactly why Paul brings up David to illustrate justification without the Law.

Let me explain. David was clearly in the wrong. He had committed adultery (II Sam. 11:1-4). Under the Law of Moses, there was simply no prescribed sacrifice for adultery; rather, the penalty for committing this sin was death (Lev. 20:10). And yet, David was not put to death. Rather, in Psalm 32 (from which Paul quotes in Romans 4), David describes a blessedness which was unheard of at that time. Not only was he not put to death for his sin, he was actually forgiven! And he was not forgiven because he offered a sacrifice (there's no prescribed sacrifice in the Law of Moses for the sin of adultery). David experienced forgiveness "apart from the Law." This simply was not the "rule" at that time, and this is why Paul brings it up in Romans 4. What was truly an exceptional case under the Law is standard procedure under Grace!

Appendix 2 - "The Calvinist Connection"

It has been my observation that many "Lordship" teachers are strongly Calvinistic in their theology. This was brought home to me recently after a message I preached at my church. The subject was "The Mystery of the Gospel" based on Ephesians 6:19. In this message, I affirmed that salvation was based on grace and obtained solely through faith, with good works playing no part either as a requirement or as a show of that faith. After the message, a visitor walked to the front, and informed me in no uncertain terms, that what I had preached was "heresy." He further stated, "This is your first warning, I hope I do not have to warn you again." I immediately suspected that I had a "Lordship Salvationist" on my hands!

Now, it should be understood that "Lordship" teachers come in two varieties: Armenian and Calvinist. The Armenian variety teaches that one must maintain faith and good works in order to retain salvation. According to this view, failure to maintain faith and works results in a loss of salvation. On the other hand, the Calvinistic variety of "Lordship" teaching states that because the Christian had no part in believing in the first place, it is God who causes him to "persevere" to the end and therefore be saved.

Now, back to our church visitor. Desiring to know whether I had an Arminian or Calvinist "Lordship" proponent, I asked this man, "Do you believe in eternal security?" True to form, he answered, "I believe in perseverance of the saints." Immediately, I knew which variety I was speaking to. Then, more out of curiosity than anything else, I asked, "Are you a Five-Pointer?" To which he simply and unashamedly answered "Yes." Incidentally, I met this man in a store shortly after this and pressed him as to whether he really believed in "Limited Atonement" (one of the Five Points of Calvinism). I then quoted I John 2:2: "And he is the propitiation for our sins, and not for ours only, but ALSO FOR THE SINS OF THE WHOLE WORLD" as well as II Peter 2:1 which refers to "false prophets" and "false teachers" who are "denying THE LORD THAT BOUGHT THEM." To this, he gazed at the floor and quietly said "I know..." Then he looked up at me and said, "Well, I'm a four and a half pointer!" So much for consistency!

What does all of this have to do with a "Calvinist connection" to Lordship Salvation? It centers around the belief in "Perseverance of the Saints" (the fifth point of Calvinism). Now, the sad part of this is that when most believers hear the words, "Perseverance of the Saints," they think it means "Eternal Security." But the truth is, these are two very different doctrines. The Westminster confession states, "True believers, by reason of the unchangeable love of God and his decree and covenant to give them perseverance ... cannot fall away..." (Westminster Confession, Chapter 19, Article 3). Ironically, Arminianism and Calvinism actually teach the same thing to a degree. That is, the believer must persevere to the end in order to be saved. The only difference is that Arminians teach that the responsibility to persevere rests upon the believer, and the Calvinists teach that perseverance is a gift bestowed by God upon "the elect." I am personally convinced that the Calvinist doctrine of “perseverance" is actually derived from the Kingdom gospel, and illustrated by Christ's words to Peter: "Simon, Simon, behold, Satan hath desired to have you (plural, the apostles), that he may sift you as wheat; But I have prayed for thee (singular, Peter himself), THAT THY FAITH FAIL NOT. And when thou art converted, strengthen thy brethren" (Luke 22:31,32).

Eternal security, on the other hand, is not a matter of the believer continuing in faith, but rather, it is based on the sealing ministry of the Holy Spirit: "In whom ye also trusted, after that ye heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation: in whom also after that ye believed, YE WERE SEALED WITH THAT HOLY SPIRIT OF PROMISE, which is the earnest of our inheritance until the redemption of the purchased possession, unto the praise of his glory" (Eph. 1:13,14). Indeed, a person who is saved may come to a point where he no longer believes. But if he was truly saved in the first place, he is still saved: "If we believe not, yet he abideth faithful: he cannot deny himself' (II Tim. 2:13). And as members of the body of Christ, we are part of the "Himself' which He cannot deny (salvation). Having said this, let me affirm, it would be a rare thing for a truly saved individual to ever come to a point of no longer believing. I am simply saying that according to the apostle Paul, this is possible, though unusual.

Yet, the Calvinistic doctrine of "Perseverance of the Saints" demands that any true believer must (or, will) continue to believe until death. Therefore it is just one small step to also insist that a true believer will also live in submission to the Lordship of Christ as

a result of being endued with “irresistible grace." This is the heart of the "Calvinist connection" to Lordship Salvation.

Appendix 3 – "Is There Security for Old Testament (and Kingdom) Saints?"

I believe in Eternal Security. I have believed this for as long as I can remember. I was saved at the age of seven, and have never believed it was possible for me to lose my salvation. I continued to believe in Eternal Security even though my high school Sunday School teacher taught against the doctrine of Eternal Security. I continued to believe in Eternal Security during my Bible Institute years when I was struggling to interpret Hebrews chapter six as addressed to us today, yet at the same time be true to a proper exegesis of the text. I believe in Eternal Security now more than ever, since I have come to understand the unique revelation committed to the Apostle Paul for the Gentiles.

I do not believe that Old Testament saints had Eternal Security. I used to believe this, but I no longer do. Some have felt (and told me so) that denying security for Old Testament saints weakens our position on Eternal Security for us today. I believe the opposite is true. Applying the principle of "rightly dividing the word of truth" actually serves to strengthen our position on Eternal Security. For now we can easily explain all those non-Pauline passages which so clearly seem to deny Eternal Security. We will look at some of these later.

First, let me say that I do NOT believe that any Old Testament saint ever lost his (or her) salvation. Now I know what some of the readers are thinking: "How can he say he does not believe in Eternal Security for Old Testament saints, and then turn around and say he does not believe any of them ever lost their salvation." Very simply: I do not believe the Old Testament (or Kingdom) saints received salvation at the BEGINNING of their faith (as we do). The Apostle Peter describes the nature of Kingdom salvation in his epistles: "Receiving the END of your faith, even the SALVATION OF YOUR SOULS" (I Pet. 1:9). "Wherefore gird up the loins of your mind, be sober, and HOPE TO THE END for the grace THAT IS TO BE brought unto you at the revelation of Jesus Christ" (I Pet. 1:13). The author to the Hebrews echoes the same thought: "But we are not of them who draw back unto perdition; but of them that believe TO THE SAVING OF THE SOUL" (Heb. 10:39). Christ taught the same thing: "Then said Jesus to those Jews which believed on him, IF YE CONTINUE IN MY WORD, then are ye my disciples indeed" (John 8:31). "He that ENDURETH TO THE END shall be saved" (Matt. 10:22b; see Matt. 24:13). I realize that many apply the "endure to the end" passages ONLY to physical salvation from the Tribulation, but in the light of the aforementioned texts, it certainly agrees with the need to continue in faith TO THE SAVING OF THE SOUL (I Pet. 1:9; Heb. 10:39).

The attempt to ascribe Eternal Security to Old Testament saints has led to some real problems of interpretation for those who try to explain certain passages. For example, Ezekiel 18:24, "But when the righteous turneth away from his righteousness, and committeth iniquity, and doeth according to all the abominations that the wicked man

doeth, shall he live? ALL HIS RIGHTEOUSNESS THAT HE RATH DONE SHALL NOT BE MENTIONED- in his trespass that he hath trespassed, and IN HIS SIN THAT HE HATH SINNED, IN THEM SHALL HE DIE." The New Scofield does a real "dance" here, explaining that the "righteousness may refer to ceremonial religion" and the "punishment threatened may refer only to physical death." You will note the uncertainty of this comment by the use of the word, "may." As to the contention that this righteousness "may" refer to ceremonial religion, two facts must be remembered. First, under the law, it WAS important to keep the ceremonial religion BY FAITH. Secondly, the text goes on to say, "Again, when the wicked man turneth away from his wickedness that he hath committed, and doeth that which is lawful AND RIGHT, he shall save his soul alive" (Ezek. 18:27). The righteousness being referred to in this context is obviously more than merely ceremonial. And as to the punishment being only physical, we would agree that under the law, a physical punishment is in view, but it also states that the individual would die "IN HIS SIN" (vs. 24). Will a person who dies "in his sin" be saved? We hardly think so! Ezekiel 18 clearly describes a case of a person who once possessed righteousness" (not "salvation," by the way) but then subsequently lost that righteousness. It is only when we try to "read into" this text the glorious Pauline teachings on righteousness, that we run into problems of interpretation.

John chapter eight gives an example of some who believed on Christ, but did not continue in that faith. "As he (Christ) spake these words, MANY BELIEVED ON HIM. Then said Jesus to those Jews WHICH BELIEVED ON HIM, If ye continue in my word, then are ye may disciples indeed" (John 8:30,31). But as we read further on in the text, we find that they did not continue in His word, for just a few verses later, Christ says to these same people, "Ye are of your father the devil..." (John 8:44). Again, many, trying to read Eternal Security into the Kingdom Program will say, "perhaps they only believed mentally, but not in their heart." If this is so, then why did not the Holy Spirit tell us? When the Scripture says someone "believed on Him" I simply take it that they "believed on Him." But it is quite obvious that they no longer believed on Him by the time you get to verse forty-four. Others have suggested that you have a different group of people by the time you come to verse forty-four. Again, we ask, if this is so, why did not the Holy Spirit inform us. The verses between John 8:31 and 44 simply record the continuing conversation Christ had with "those Jews which believed on Him." There is no break in the conversation or change of audience.

A major stumbling block for many Christians has been the failure to properly interpret Hebrews chapter six. Here, the writer clearly states that "it is IMPOSSIBLE for those who were once enlightened, and have tasted of the heavenly gift, and were made partakers of the Holy Ghost, And have tasted the good word of God, and the powers of the world to come, If they shall fall away, to renew them again unto repentance; seeing they crucify to themselves the Son of God afresh, and put him to an open shame" (Heb. 6:4-6). Once more, the interpreters have "out-done" themselves trying to reconcile this text with Eternal Security. A common explanation is that the people in question came to the brink of faith, but did not actually believe. The expression, "tasted the good word of God" is sometimes used to prove this view. "They only sampled, but did not swallow it," some have suggested. Is this what the word "tasted" conveys? Let Scripture interpret

itself In the same epistle, the same word is used of Christ, "But we see Jesus, who was made a little lower that the angels for the suffering of death, crowned with glory and honour; that he by the grace of God should TASTE death for every man" (Heb. 2:9). Does this mean that Christ sampled death, but didn't actually die? Of course not! He fully partook of death for every man. And likewise, the people in Hebrews six fully partook of the word of God. Furthermore, they were made "partakers of the Holy Ghost" (Heb. 6:4). This was the Pentecostal outpouring of the Holy Spirit recorded in Acts 2:4,17&18. These were clearly believers, yet the author of Hebrews says that if they "fall away," it is "impossible" to "renew them unto repentance." Let us stop trying to twist the Scripture to say something it does not say. Instead, let us "rightly divide the Word of truth" and we will not need to twist the Scriptures. We only lose credibility when we try to "read into" the Hebrew Scriptures the great Pauline doctrines.

Another "no security" passage is Hebrews 10:26,27 - "For if we sin willfully after that we have received the knowledge of the truth, there remaineth no more sacrifice for sins, But a certain fearful looking for OF JUDGMENT AND FIERY INDIGNATION, which shall devour the adversaries." Here the author is clearly referring to believers, for he includes himself, "if WE sin willfully..." Yet to the person who does so, they are told to expect "judgment and fiery indignation." And this is no mere chastening or loss of reward, for the fire they can expect is the same fire which shall "devour the adversaries." Again, we ask, why twist this plain warning to mean something other than what it says, when "rightly dividing the word of truth" can solve the paradox so easily? THIS PASSAGE APPLIES TO THE HEBREWS, NOT THE BODY OF CHRIST!

Peter utters the same warning: "For if after they have escaped the pollution's of the world through the knowledge of the Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, they are again entangled therein, and overcome, the latter end is worse with them than the beginning. For it had been better for them not to have known the way of righteousness, than, after they have known it, to turn from the holy commandment delivered unto them" (II Pet. 2:20,21). Think about this warning for a moment. If this passage refers to people who have eternal security, how would it have "been better for them NOT TO HAVE KNOWN THE WAY OF RIGHTEOUSNESS?" If they had never known the way of righteousness, they would surely be damned. If they have eternal security, at least they are saved, even though they lose rewards. "Well," some would say, "perhaps they were not saved in the first place." And again, we would ask, how would a person be better off never knowing the way of righteousness, than to hear about it, but not believe? Both ways, you end up in hell! The only way Peter's warning makes any sense is to leave it in the Kingdom Program, where once they believe, but then fall away, it is impossible" to "renew them again unto repentance" (Heb. 6:4-6). In this case, it would truly be better to never have heard the way of righteousness, for at least then they would still have the possibility of eventually being saved.

John echoes this same principle, "If any man see his brother sin a sin which is not unto death, he shall ask, and he shall give him life for them that sin unto death: I do not say that he shall pray for it" (I John 5:16). Many interpret the "death" here to be only the physical chastening of sin. If this is so, why would we be told not to pray for this

"brother?" Under grace, we should always pray for a brother who has sinned! But under the Kingdom Program, it is possible to commit a certain category of sin which is unforgivable, and therefore it would do no good to pray for it. What kind of sin would this be? The Old Testament calls it a "presumptuous sin." "But the soul that doeth ought presumptuously, whether he be born in the land, or a stranger, the same reproacheth the LORD; and that soul shall be cut off from among his people. Because he hath despised the word of the LORD, and hath broken his commandment, that soul shall utterly be cut off; HIS INIQUITY SHALL BE UPON HIM" (Numb. 15:30,31). A presumptuous sin was open rebellion against God, and John says not to pray for a "brother" who commits such a sin.

In the Revelation, John records the words of Christ to be written to the angel of the church in Sardis, "He that overcometh, the same shall be clothed in white raiment; and I will not BLOT HIS NAME OUT OF THE BOOK OF LIFE, but I will confess his name before my Father, and before his angels" (Rev. 3:5). The clear implication is that those who do not "overcome" will have their name blotted out of the book of life.

In the light of these (and other) passages of Scripture, we ask, "If God had wanted to express the warning to Kingdom saints that they must guard against falling away lest they face eternal damnation, how could He have done so more forcefully than the afore-mentioned texts?" Let us leave these severe warnings alone and interpret them for what they say. Then let us "rightly divide the Word of Truth," recognizing that these warnings about the danger of losing righteousness," being "utterly cut off" with "his iniquity ... upon him," and the danger of facing the "judgment and fiery indignation which shall devour the adversaries" belong to the kingdom program, not to the dispensation of the grace of God. Do I hear any "amens?"

The question has been asked, "Does the kingdom saint ever come to a point where his salvation is secure?" The answer is, "Yes!" Two examples come to mind. But before looking at these, let us remind the reader that only Paul tells us that we are "sealed with the Holy Spirit" (II Cor. 1:22; Eph. 1:13; 4:30). This is a unique "body truth" which is simply not found elsewhere in Scripture.

But getting back to the kingdom saint, at what point do they experience security of salvation? The first instance we can point to in Scripture is that their salvation becomes sealed at death, so long as they "died in faith." You will note that I chose those words carefully because this is precisely how the author of Hebrews states this principle. In the great "Hall of Faith" found in Hebrews chapter eleven, the writer points out, "These all died in faith, not having received the promises, but having seen them afar off..." (Heb. 11:13a). Why did not the writer simply say, "These all died, not having received the promises..."? The answer is, because under the Jewish program, it is essential for the person to be believing AT THE TIME OF DEATH in order for them to be saved (remember, "he that endureth to the END," and "if ye CONTFNUE in my word, then are ye my disciples Indeed"). Therefore, the author of Hebrews clearly states, "These all DIED IN FAITH..."

A second instance of a kingdom saint receiving security is found in Revelation, where John writes, "Saying, Hurt not the earth, neither the sea, nor the trees, till we have SEALED the servants of our God in their foreheads" (Rev. 7:3). This refers to the 144,000 Israelites who receive special status during the Tribulation Period. The main purpose of this seal is to protect them from the plagues of this time period, "And it was commanded them that they should not hurt the grass of the earth, neither any green thing, neither any tree; but only those men WHICH HAVE NOT THE SEAL OF GOD IN THEIR FOREHEADS" (Rev. 9:4). But it seems apparent that this seal also has to do with their security, since a specific number is stated (144,000) and jumping ahead to chapter fourteen, they are all present and accounted for when the Lamb stands on Mount Zion (see Rev. 14:1-4). But let it be noted that ONLY these 144,000 are said to be "sealed," even though a great multitude besides these is eventually saved out of the Tribulation. No word is said about the rest of these being "sealed." Rather, the rest who are saved are overcomers who endured to the end (either of their life, or of the Tribulation).

Inevitably, when pointing out the tentative nature of Kingdom salvation, someone will ask, "Doesn't John teach the security of the believer?" A commonly used security verse is John 5:24, "Verily, verily, I say unto you, He that heareth my word, and belleveth on him that sent me, hath everlasting life, and shall not come into condemnation: but is passed from death unto life." Several observations can be made. First, this verse must be taken in the broader context of John's Gospel, and not isolated from other statements of Christ. We have already pointed out that Christ's definition of faith is to continue in my word" (John 8:31). This is actually reflected in the grammar of John 5:24. The first three verbs are in the present tense, which in Greek is the tense of continuous (or, "durative") action. Therefore, Christ is telling His hearers that those who continue hearing and continue believing will continue to enter into eternal life. Granted, the verb, "is passed" from death unto life is in the perfect tense. But all this means is that the kingdom believer is no longer in a state of separation from God, so long as he believes. It is a complete state of life, not part death and part life. The real question, though, is, can a kingdom saint fall away from his relationship with God, or Christ and fall back into a state of death? I believe the answer is "yes." This is the warning of John 15:6, "if a man abide not in me, he is cast forth as a branch, and is withered; and men gather them and cast them into the fire, AND THEY ARE BURNED." "For we are made partakers of Christ, IF WE HOLD FAST THE CONFIDENCE AND THE REJOICING OF THE HOPE FIRM UNTO THE END" (Heb. 3:14).

Another observation about John 5:24 is that Christ is obviously looking forward to the Kingdom in this context: "Verily, verily, I say unto you, The hour is coming, and now is (remember, the Mystery was not yet revealed at this point), when the dead shall hear the voice of the Son of God: and they that hear shall live" (John 5:25). This is a reference to the resurrection of kingdom saints, which will take place immediately before the Kingdom is established. Those resurrected kingdom saints will, of course, have security at that time.

Appendix 4 - "Was Abraham justified before men or God?"

James writes, "Was not Abraham, our father, justified by works, when he had offered Isaac, his son, upon the altar?" (James 2:21). One "Acts 2" brother, in a noble rebuttal of Lordship Salvation, yet desiring to still apply James to the Body of Christ, suggests that James is saying that Abraham was justified IN THE SIGHT OF MEN when he offered Isaac on the altar. Here is a case of "needing" to reconcile James with Paul, since in this brother's view, both address the "Church which is His body."

Instead, we believe that "rightly dividing the Word of Truth" solves the problem without twisting any Scripture at all. First of all, who was observing Abraham's actions when he offered Isaac? In the historical account, we read, "And Abraham said unto his young men, Abide ye here with the ass; and I and the lad will go yonder and worship, and come again to you " (Gen. 22:5). The only men around were Abraham and Isaac! It was God who observed the entire event. "And the angel of the LORD (the Old Testament designation for the pre-incarnate Christ) called unto him out of Heaven, and said, Abraham, Abraham: and he said, Here am I. And He said, Lay not thine hand upon the lad, neither do thou anything into him; for now I know that thou fearest God, seeing thou hast not withheld thy son, thine only son from me" (Gen. 22:11,12).

Secondly, in any dispensation, the goal is to be justified by God, not by men! "And when thou prayest, thou shalt not be as the hypocrites are; for they love to pray standing in the synagogues and at the corners of the streets, that they may be SEEN OF MEN. Verily I say unto you, They have their reward" (Matt. 6:5).

EPILOGUE

Nearly two millennia ago, the Apostle of the Gentiles instructed Timothy to "Hold fast the form of sound words, which thou hast heard of me, in faith and love which is in Christ Jesus. That good thing which was committed unto thee keep by the Holy Ghost which dwelleth in us" (II Tim. 1:13,14). This admonition is as timely today as when it was spoken, perhaps even more so, for now we have had two-thousand years of attacks, denials, and twisting of the great revelation of the Mystery which was committed to Paul for the Gentiles. "That good thing," or literally "the "good deposit," is the Mystery truth for this dispensation (Col. 1:24 - 2:2), and the heart of the Mystery is the Gospel of the Grace of God, which Paul affectionately calls "my Gospel."

It is heartening to see a move within the Grace Movement back towards an emphasis of the Gospel (I Cor. 15:1-4) and a call to evangelism, for all men will not see the "Dispensation of the Mystery" (Eph. 3:9) until they are first saved (see I Cor. 2:1-8). We, of all people, should preach a pure, accurate and true Gospel, free from the various law and works mixtures proclaimed by Lordship Salvationists. It is to this end this book is written.

Finally, should a dear, lost soul have picked up this volume, we beg you in Christ's stead, "be ye reconciled to God" (II Cor. 5:20). Christ died for your sins, was buried,

and rose again for you, and is even now waiting for you to trust Him for your salvation. Will you believe the Gospel today?